



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Analyzing the electoral impact of political and legal restrictions on far-right parties: Evidence from Greece

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Abstract

One century after the rising wave of fascism, our world is facing the electoral surge of the far-right. Parties with illiberal identity have flooded several European political systems, aiming to erode democracy. This spike has cultivated renewed interest in militant democracy-restrictive measures implemented by established actors in democracies, aiming to restrict illiberal parties. However, there is a dilemma when it comes to the imposition of restrictions on illiberal parties in democracies, as there is always the danger of self-injury.

Existing literature on electoral consequences of restrictions remains ambiguous. While some studies indicate that restrictions delegitimize the targeted party, others suggest they victimize it, strengthening its power.

My thesis departs from previous analyses which focus on restrictive measures in isolation, introducing different levels of restrictions' intensity in a comparative way. I investigate the effects of three different restrictions, namely political ostracism, cuts on state funding, and a potential party ban on voting intention, on a fictitious far-right party. Results from my analysis suggest that ostracism and cuts on funding do not affect intention to vote for the party, while a potential party ban exerts a statistically significant decrease of 0.6 points towards the party on the 7-point scale of voting intention. This suggests that the most coercive measure is the most effective one, in mitigating party's appeal, supporting the delegitimization hypothesis. These findings carry substantive policy implications for democratic actors regarding the attentive use of restrictions towards the far-right.

Use of AI

The use of AI is consistent with the University's Ethics and Integrity Guide, as AI tools have been used only for editing language after the completion of the thesis, as well as minor edits to Stata commands used for my quantitative analysis. Other than that, AI has not been used for any other purposes in my master thesis.

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Introduction

It was almost four decades ago, when Fukuyama and other prominent researchers on democratization theories declared liberal democracy's everlasting domination. This seems doubtful today, as our world is plagued by a rapid third wave of autocratization (Boese et al., 2021; Luhrmann & Lindberg, 2019). An alarming number of democratic regimes are facing the decline of political freedoms, as democratically elected incumbents are exerting tendencies of authoritarianism (van Lit et al., 2024). A key reason for this, is grounded on the incremental electoral success of far-right parties. Many of these parties have experienced noteworthy success in several European countries, including Italy, the Netherlands, Sweden, Austria, Hungary, France, and Germany (Aktas, 2024; Bourne, 2022). This political turn has triggered a vast amount of research related to this issue. Most of the research pieces produced are alarming, as these parties are generally visualized as a threat to liberal democracy, mainly due to their pro-authoritarian, and chauvinistic identity (Mudde, 2004). Consequently, their electoral surge has altered the structure and terms of political competition across Europe, as well as the salient issues and social cleavages in them, eroding democracy from the "inside".

In fact, these latest developments have generated renewed interest in the concept of militant democracy. Drawing insights from Capoccia, (2013), Lowenstein (1937), and Müller (2012, p.1253), militant democracy refers to the idea that "a democratic regime adopts illiberal measures on political expression and participation to curb extremist actors". However, there is a counterintuitive tension that exists between autocratization and the possible institutional toolkit that can defend democracy. This is often referred to as the "democratic dilemma", which centers on the possibility that democracies will destroy their core identity in the attempt to defend themselves (Müller, 2012; Capoccia, 2013). To elaborate, in response to the rise of far-right parties, political and legal structures in several European countries have pursued a variety of strategies from exclusion and delegitimization to isolation (Downs, 2001; Lührmann et al., 2020; Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017). According to Downs (2001, p.26), political actors have two different options to react to what is often called "extremist threats". To

disengage with them, following initiatives closer to the notion of “militant” democracy, or to engage and be more tolerant of them.

Although there is a growing literature analyzing the different tools in the arsenal of militant democracy, the findings on how democratic self-defense measures influence electoral behavior are inconsistent. While some studies suggest that imposed restrictions delegitimize illiberal parties (Arenas, 2021; Bale, 2007; Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009; Van Spanje and Azrout, 2019), others demonstrate that these measures have unintended consequences, creating a sense of victimization for the targeted party, strengthening its electoral appeal (Jacobs & Van Spanje, 2020; Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017). Thus, the existing tension lies on which mechanism that affects voting behavior do the different militant democratic restrictions activate.

Restrictive measures can be imposed on parties with various ideological attributes, however my emphasis will be on the far-right ones. There are two reasons that justify this choice. First, these parties constitute the most common receivers of militant restrictions, such as party bans, compared to other categories of party families (Bourne & Bertoa, 2017). The second justification lies on the electoral spike of far-right, signaling that they are becoming increasingly crucial players in European politics (Aktas, 2024).

To explore this phenomenon, this thesis will focus on the following research question. *To what extent do the different types of political and legal restrictions on far-right parties affect the electoral support for them?* Reflecting on this, I empirically investigate the electoral effects of three different restrictions on a fictitious far-right party with the use of a randomized survey experiment in Greece. While the existing literature focuses more on analyzing the electoral effect of single restrictive measures, this thesis centers on a comparative perspective, introducing different levels of restrictions’ intensity. My focus will be on the following “self-defense” measures. First, political ostracism, which signals a political exclusionary approach. Second, cut of state funding, which constitutes a legal restriction. Finally, a potential party ban. Broadly speaking, this thesis contributes to the ongoing political debate about a highly contemporary world political issue, the implications of restrictive measures, providing explanations for the mixed nature of their effects, based on their intensity.

What emerges from the results showed that milder restrictions, such as political ostracism, and cut on state funding produces no statistically significant effect on voting intention, suggesting that these measures do not activate any of the delegitimization or the victimization mechanism. However, strong evidence was found regarding the effect of party ban on voting intention. Further analysis showed that the imposition of a potential party ban holds a negative and statistically significant effect, as it decreases the voting intention by 0.6 points at the 7-point scale, towards Party X, compared to the control group, controlling for other potential factors. This evidence supports the delegitimization hypothesis, suggesting that in the Greek political context, the most coercive measure is the only one that moves public opinion in terms of voting behavior, while the two milder restrictions mainly affect the organizational capacity of the party, leaving electoral behavior unaffected. Overall, these results carry substantive policy implications regarding the implementation of restrictive measures for established democratic actors, which will be discussed mainly at the concluding chapter of my thesis.

To my knowledge, there is no previous research analyzing how the different variation in the intensity of restrictive measures towards parties affect the voting support for them. This thesis addresses this gap, contributing to the literature in two different ways. First, it offers a comparative evaluation of the electoral effects of different measures rather than focusing on the effect of a single self-defense measure in isolation. Second, it creates a framework of analysis of restrictions' electoral effects, based on their intensity variation with the use of an experimental design in the case of Greece. Thus, my thesis contributes to different literatures, from militant democracy to democratic self-defense approaches, and from published studies explaining far-right party support to democratic backsliding research themes.

I have organized the rest of my thesis in the following way. First, I will set the stage with a brief analysis regarding the identity of far-right parties. In this section, I will analyze how these actors erode democracies. Moving on, I will turn my attention to militant democracy, sketching its conceptual framework. In this section, I will analyze different strategies implemented by mainstream actors to mitigate the influence of these parties. Furthermore, I will demonstrate a synopsis of the ambiguous findings regarding

the electoral implications of restrictions, as well as provide theoretical explanations for them. This is followed by the empirical design of my survey, and the methodological approach to explore my research question. A subsequent section will discuss the empirical findings of the experiment and evaluate my theoretical expectations. Finally, I will conduct a brief discussion about my concluding remarks and their broader implications.

1. Far-right parties and the erosion of Liberal Democracy

As discussed in the introductory part, this opening chapter will set the background for my analysis by introducing the readers briefly to the identity of far-right parties and the classification of their characteristics. According to Sartori (1984), “the rebuilding and understanding of a concept begins by looking into its literature and extracting its characteristics” (see Pappas, 2019). In fact, the far-right party family is now the most studied party family, due to its reemergence (Aktas, 2024; Golder, 2016). But my purpose here is neither to debate analytically the different variants of the far right nor to analyze the reasons for their success. However, I find it fruitful to invest some of my effort to explore the ideological makeup of these parties and thus the reasons why they are perceived as a threat to liberal democracy. This will enhance the reader's understanding of why established democratic actors impose restrictions on them.

1.1 In the pursuit of an ideological conceptual “umbrella”

The term “new nationalism” is often used to describe the reemergence of parties that share their emphasis on restoring national sovereignty, strict anti-immigrant positions, anti-elitism, welfare chauvinism, as well as skepticism against supranational institutions (Halikiopoulou & Vlandas, 2019). However, far-right scholars lack a clear consensus regarding the distinct attributes that constitute the ideology of this party family (Golder, 2016). For instance, Mudde's analysis (1996) identifies 58 different characteristics linked with the far-right. Golder (2016) mentions that this lack of definitional consensus leads to a plethora of different names used to define these parties. More specifically, some good illustrations of the different terms used to describe them are, right-wing populist, radical right, extreme right, anti-immigrant, and far right. One plausible answer to support the anti-immigrant naming, comes from Fennema (1997) and Ivarsflaten (2007), who suggest that it was the immigration crisis that triggered incremental demand of these parties. Therefore, they suggest that it would be practical to refer to them as “anti-immigrant” parties. However, Mudde (1999) proposes that it is the ideological attribute of nativism that affects their policy stances across the board,

indicating that literature should not treat them as monothematic parties. Recent scholars highlight that the common denominator that makes these parties comparable and easily identified, is not populism, or the anti-immigrant stance, but nationalism (Golder, 2016; Vasilopoulou & Halikiopoulou, 2015). A similar analysis by Rydgren (2017) indicates that although populism is a motivational power, it should not be treated as the common distinctive feature of them, as there are other parties of different aspects of the political spectrum that can be said to be populist in some way. Thus, Halikiopoulou & Vlandas (2019) point out that a “one size fits-all” explanation to conceptualize these parties overlooks significant differences in terms of their ideological extremity, the use of violence, their economic or social agenda, even the degree to which they accept procedural democracy. Reflecting on these, and to avoid conceptual blurring, I argue that it is more analytically useful to adopt the term “far right” as a conceptual “umbrella” to describe these parties, as it better accounts for the high diversity between attributes of their ideological makeup. However, in continuing of the analysis, one should not forget that populism remains a core attribute encapsulated in the identity of far-right parties.

1.2 Towards a common ideological composition of far-right identity

Despite the above conceptual discrepancy, over the last years scholars have classified members of the far-right family, depending on the three core attributes of nationalism, populism, and extremism/authoritarianism (Golder, 2016; Mudde, 2004).

Firstly, nationalism is described as a common ideological feature of far right (Mudde, 2007; Rydgren, 2017). According to Bonikowski et al. (2019), “nationalism refers to an antagonistic relationship between two ethnically or culturally heterogeneous groups, the in-group and the out-group”. It is often described as a “thin ideology” (Freeden, 1998; Halikiopoulou et al., 2012; Mudde, 2004), seeking the preservation of the unity, and the identity of the nation (Breuilly 2005, as cited in Halikiopoulou & Vlandas, 2019). However, the concept of nationalism is not attributed as an ideological feature only to the far-right party family (Rydgren, 2017). What distinguishes nationalism of the far right from that of established parties, is nativism. Mudde (2007) describes nativism as a notion combining nationalism with xenophobic stances against the non-

native elements, the existence of which threatens the monocultural nature of the nation-state.

Halikiopoulou et al. (2013) emphasize that what makes the contemporary far-right parties successful is their focus on offering nationalist solutions to all the different types of insecurities affecting electoral behavior. More specifically, the Front National (FN) in France, Alternative für Deutschland (AfD), the Dutch PVV, the Austrian Freedom Party (FPÖ), the Sweden Democrats (SD), and Vox in Spain, are some good illustrations of successful European far-right parties that have capitalized on various voters' insecurities, by using a civic nationalist rhetoric. This means that they exclude groups from state provisions, based on ideological rather than biological criteria of national belonging (Halikiopoulou & Vlandas, 2019). A good depiction of this, draws on the narrative that there are certain cultures or religions (e.g., Islam) that demonstrate intolerance and antithesis to democratic values. Thus, these parties indicate that it is the ideology of Islam in this case, that threatens the liberal democratic nature of Western states, and therefore ideas should be excluded and demonized.

The high significance of nationalism-nativism as a basis for their policies can also be reflected in economic planning. To explain this, far-right parties tend to focus on welfare chauvinism, as well as on policies of national preference. This requires the government to intervene and guarantee jobs for the native population and prioritize them for social welfare benefits (Afonso & Papadopoulos, 2015; Golder, 2016). This encapsulates the desire to put "our own people first" (Golder, 2016).

In line with nativism, populism is also a central concept to the electoral success of many far-right parties (Betz, 1993; Betz & Immerfall, 1998; Taggart, 1996, 2000). Populism is undeniably one of the most used and abused terms inside and outside of academic research. Even in the academic literature, populism is used to describe a range of very different phenomena as well as a broad variety of host ideologies and actors (Mudde & Kaltwasser, 2012). According to Mudde (2004), populism refers to the relationship between "the elite" and "the people", or "the people versus the powerful". Despite this preliminary analysis, the question of what exactly populism is, an ideology, a political syndrome, or a communication strategy, is far from clear. Therefore, using the conceptualization by Mudde (2004, p.543), I attempt to capture and clearly define this

contested concept, as “an ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two different homogenous, but also antagonistic groups”. On the one hand, “the pure people”, against “the corrupt elite”. In this competitive relationship, populism arises as an idea arguing that politics should be an expression of the general will of the people. For this reason, populism is often described as a form of “democratic illiberalism” (Pappas, 2016). It is democratic, as it draws on people’s will, but it is also illiberal as it seeks to bypass the institutional checks and balances of the liberal democracy (Bonikowski et al. 2019; Freedon, 2017). However, the far-right proponents of populism see themselves as the defenders of true democracy (Golder, 2016).

The last defining characteristic of the far-right family is extremism. Mudde (2010) distinguishes the far-right parties into two categories, based on the degree of extremism: the radical ones, and the extremist ones. On the one hand, the radical category consists of parties that clearly accept the procedural type of liberal democracy, opposing the far-right label (Halikiopoulou & Vlandas, 2019). In other words, their radicalism calls for immediate political and economic reforms, however they do not explicitly seek to eliminate the democratic nature of society (Golder, 2016). The key to achieving this, is the civic nationalist narrative (Halikiopoulou et al., 2013). On the other hand, the extreme ones are parties directly opposed to democracy. This category encapsulates both vigilante groups and political parties clearly tied with fascism, racism, and the use of violence as a crucial means for achieving their political goals (Golder, 2016; Halikiopoulou & Vlandas, 2019). In this level of analysis, I should mention that the dividing line between radicalism and extremism is very hard to establish, and that it would be analytically arbitrary to suppose that radicalism should be considered as a moderate form of extremism. One important consideration of what these two distinct categories have in common is “their desire to create an authoritarian system of power ordered according to the “natural” difference that exists in society, as well as a law-and-order system that punishes deviant behavior” (Mudde, 2007).

This combination of shared attributes of nativism, authoritarianism, and populism on behalf of this political family has an adverse relationship with democracy and its components. Milačić & Vukovic (2017) argue that the success of the far right can be visualized as a shadow, haunting democracies throughout the world, including Europe. Hence, in the next section of my analysis, I will focus on how the existence of these

parties leads to an erosion of the democratic norms and citizens' attitudes about the value of democracy in various European political systems.

1.3 Democratic eroders on action

Before moving to the next chapter regarding militant democracy and the responses of the established democratic actors against the far right, it is important to continue building my theoretical puzzle, by understanding the ways in which these parties erode basic democratic principles. “To elaborate on this, according to Meléndez & Kaltwasser (2017), far-right parties combine populism and a strong notion of anti-pluralism with the attribute of nativism. In line with that, Downs (2001) described their ideology as “an anti-democratic with anti-elite characteristics, which rejects the principle of fundamental human and political equality”. This latter attribute comes in direct contrast with one of the core principles of liberal democracy, the political equality of citizens. (as cited in Filios, 2025)

“First, while a certain degree of skepticism for the elites may be healthy for a democracy, these parties use anti-elitism to undermine democratic political competition. In a way, they challenge the pluralist foundation of democracy, which embraces that societies are composed of social groups with different ideas and interests (Mudde & Kaltwasser, 2013). Moreover, these populist actors usually make the claim that the results of governance from the mainstream parties are relatively poor. To remediate this situation, they propose to adjust the procedural dimension of the system by strengthening popular sovereignty at the cost of constitutionalism. More specifically, they use the notion of popular sovereignty to erode the “checks and balances” system and the separation of powers. Consequently, this deteriorates democratic quality by facilitating a process of democratic erosion, in the case of consolidated democracies, or democratic breakdown, in the case of unconsolidated democracies (Mudde & Kaltwasser, 2012). It is quite interesting that far-right parties have played a central role in the current wave of autocratization, which has emerged as an alarming global challenge. For instance, in countries such as Brazil, Hungary, Russia, Serbia, and Turkey, which have recently experienced democratic setbacks, governments have been led by leaders of this political family (Altman, 2017; Bermeo, 2016). Bermeo (2016)

suggests that this erosion tends to be gradual and under legal disguise, when these leaders come into power. In many cases, these autocracies mainly use legal means to grab power and erode democracy with different forms of executive aggrandizement (Luhrmann & Lindberg, 2019). The idea of executive aggrandizement mainly refers to occasions, where presidents gradually dismantle institutional checks on their power. Consequently, this leads to a significant degradation of democratic quality and democratic backsliding (Bermeo, 2016). A precise linkage with the relationship between the far right and this form of democratic erosion has been well highlighted by Bessen (2024), mentioning that “populist discourse increases support for executive aggrandizement by framing presidents as champions of ‘the people’ and institutional opposition as a barrier to the popular will”. Research has also convincingly implied that far-right parties pose a major pathogen for democracy, due to the weakening of political institutions and judicial independence, the marginalization of specific groups of society, as well as the undermining of minority rights (Mudde & Kaltwasser, 2012; Mudde, 2004). Mudde (2004) highlights the propagandistic nature of these parties, which deepens the populist cleavages and the polarization level between “the people” and “the corrupt elite” (as cited in Filios, 2025).

In the same vein, Davis et al. (2025) explain that the populist, and illiberal nature of these parties lead to greater affective polarization among all citizens. “They mention that this effect grows as populism and illiberalism increase. This diffusion of illiberal rhetoric into democracies negatively affects vulnerable citizens’ commitment to democratic norms. In line with Luhrmann (2021), these actors skillfully claim to address democratic discontent while fueling it and masking their anti-democratic aspirations with populist speech. In a way, not only do they fuel polarization, but also, they benefit from it. Therefore, the question that arises from the above analysis is, what can democratic political actors do to secure democratic resilience against this phenomenon?” (as cited in Filios, 2025). To put it more simply, how should democracy defend itself and fight these parties?

2. Democratic self-defense approaches and the notion of Militant Democracy

The following chapter will introduce the readers to the main framework around which my research focus revolves. More precisely, it will present the context and the notion of militant democracy, different types of democratic opposition to illiberal far-right actors, as well as the inconsistent findings regarding the electoral consequences of the various democratic responses employed against targeted parties.

2.1 Militant Democracy: The basis of democratic self-preservation

The third current wave of autocratization that our world is experiencing has triggered a vast body of literature regarding the causes behind this development, as well as strategies on how democratic actors can respond to this crisis. Reflecting on this, the dilemma that arises draws on whether democracies take measures against political actors committed to the abolition of democracy through nonviolent means or not. The concept of militant democracy answers this dilemma in the affirmative (Müller, 2016, p. 250). Although there is no consensus in the literature on a definition of militant democracy, sometimes also called “defensive democracy” or “fighting democracy”, “it refers to the idea of a democratic regime, which is willing to use legal restrictions on political expression and participation to curb extremist actors” (Capoccia, 2013; Lowenstein, 1937; Müller 2012, p.1253).

The idea of militant democracy was first introduced by Karl Lowenstein in 1937. The core view was that European democracies were structurally incapable of defending themselves against the rising wave of fascism in Italy, and Germany, if they continued to attach themselves to “democratic fundamentalism”, “legalistic blindness”, and an “exaggerated formalism of the rule of law” (Lowenstein, 1937, p. 424). A broadly similar point emphasizes that democracies should adopt special restrictive measures to prevent leaders from exploiting what Goebbels defined as the “best joke of democracy is that it gave its deadly enemies the means by which it was destroyed” (as quoted in Fox & Nolte, 1995, p.1). In other words, democracies should fight “fire with fire” (Capoccia 2013; Kaltwasser, 2019; Klamt, 2007, Lowenstein, 1937). One crucial

reason behind militant democracy's renaissance today is the political breakthrough of novel concerns about anti-democratic, and illiberal doctrines, aiming to erode liberal democratic order (Rawls, 1993, p.64). In response to this, the old neutral, tolerant model of liberal democracy, according to which, all views are entitled to the same level of respect, has currently given up its place to a consensus that restrictions on basic rights aiming to preserve democracy are legitimate (Capoccia, 2013). Along the same lines, Bernatskyi (2024) argues that defending democracy by imposing the militant model requires some undemocratic steps, that contemporary democracies will face, by restricting some actors' rights. The most frequent and most orthodox instruments of militant democracy are party bans, as well as restrictions on the freedom of speech (Müller 2016; Bourne & Bertoa, 2017; Malkopoulou, 2021). In line with that, Lowenstein (1937, p. 638) proposes a longer list of militant measures, including legislative proposals, such as restrictions of parliamentary immunity, freedom of assembly, opinion, and press. The core of militant democracy lies on that democracies should defend themselves, even at the risk of violating fundamental principles (Müller, 2012; Lowenstein, 1937).

Nowadays, a high number of democratic countries include some of these measures in their legislation, and consequently, in this sense some degree of militancy is a commonplace (Malkopoulou, 2019; Tyulkina et al., 2019). However, this in fact creates a considerable cross-national variation in the formal legal design and the implementation of militant restrictions on targeted actors, related to the historical legacies of the authoritarian past, and the institutional context (Capoccia, 2013, 2019; Thiel, 2016). In support of these developments, Müller (2012) argues that even within at a shared political space, such as the European Union, it is highly unlikely for scholars to move towards a conceptual convergence of militant democracy. In the same vein, Rosenblum (2010) emphasizes the role of "militant democracy not as a distinctive standardized model but rather, as an abstract normative concept that can be rendered more precise with many different moral, political, and legal-institutional conceptions, often highly dependent on national context". Apart from the absence of a general conceptual framework, the justifications for the implementation of militant democracy even within countries have remained unclear, and contested (Kaltwasser, 2019; Müller, 2012). To illustrate, contemporary actors subjected to restrictions are not just openly competing with democracies, subverting their nature, as it seemed to be the case in the

20th century with the authoritarian movements of fascism, and Nazism (Capoccia, 2013; Thiel, 2016). In other words, it is much more difficult to detect the supposed “real enemies” of contemporary democracies.

From the above analysis, it is becoming difficult to compare and understand the different types of militancy. Up until today, very few national legal systems explicitly employ the language of militancy, and self-protective restrictions against illiberal actors (Tyulkina et al., 2019; Müller, 2012). Therefore, a distinction in terms of classifying whether a democracy is a militant one or not, is obviously impractical, and analytically pointless, as almost every legal system encapsulates a degree of militancy (Thiel, 2016). Another set of classification draws on the distinction between procedural and substantive models of democracy (Fox & Nolte, 1995). On the one hand, procedural models conceive democracy as an institutional arrangement for choosing leaders. In this type, tolerance is a transcendent norm, and there are no guarantees that democracy will always prevail, as rights should not be used to restrict other rights. On the other hand, substantive democracies do not allow constitutional amendments, protecting the nature of democracy (Bourne, 2022; Bourne & Bertoa, 2017).

However, the scope of this thesis is not to focus on providing a classification of militant models, but to examine the electoral effects of different political and legal restrictions. Thus, given this lack of conceptual convergence on militant democracy, this thesis will move on to analyze the different tools of democratic self-defense approaches. In fact, the subsequent section will focus on examining democratic initiatives opposing illiberal extremists, who pose an identifiable threat to liberal democracy.

2.2 Strategic democratic responses opposing far-right illiberal actors

Having established the contested conceptual framework of militant democracy, I now shift the emphasis on the strategic democratic self-defense responses implemented by democratic actors. In fact, I turn my attention from theoretical concepts to practices.

To begin with, Bourne (2022) highlights that efforts to classify democratic opposition to illiberal actors have been influenced by the concept of militant democracy. However, over the last few decades, scholars have created different typologies and analytical frameworks, regarding these different strategies, focusing on a much broader range of responses. Drawing on this literature, the presentation of a holistic typology of measures will not only enable the readers to comprehend the variety of these strategies, but it will also set the stage for my empirical question, about the effect of these restrictions on the electoral support of targeted far-right parties.

As noted, our world and especially Europe has experienced a growing demand for illiberal far-right parties (Aktas, 2024). Their electoral popularity is here to stay, at least for the medium term (Bourne, 2022). “In response to this rise, the political establishment in several European countries has implemented a wide range of strategies from exclusion and delegitimization to isolation and cooperation (Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017). Democratic actors need to implement a variety of measures against these extreme opponents. This includes deploying constitutional checks and balances, constraining the power of governing parties, as well as other legal constraints to block individual reforms with anti-democratic content (Bourne, 2023). In the same logic, Downs (2001) mentions that established democratic parties in almost every European country face a fundamental dilemma upon the entry of a radical right party into a representative assembly. To disengage, or to engage? This dilemma can also be expressed in terms of the approaches to democracy, specifically between militant and tolerant democracy (Capoccia 2013; 2019). On the one hand, militant democracy is often defined “as a legally authorized, but exceptional, restriction of certain basic political rights, preventing these parties from undermining liberal democracy (Müller, 2012)” (as cited in Filios, 2025). “On the other hand, tolerant democracy is a more contested concept, vital to the functioning of modern and liberal democracies but also ambiguous (Eger & Hjerm, 2019). In line with that, Popper et al. (2012) cautioned

against unlimited tolerance, because, paradoxically, it may lead to the disappearance of tolerance itself. Therefore, he claims that “in the name of tolerance, we have the right not to tolerate the intolerant” (as cited in Filios, 2025).

Drawing on these theories, I divide my analysis into two axes. First, regarding the actors involved (political parties, public authorities, and civil society), who they sometimes can be described as interconnected sectors of engagement (Bourne, 2023). Second, the nature of the countermeasures (tolerant-engage, intolerant-disengage) (Downs, 2001, 2009; Bourne, 2023; Luhrmann et al., 2020; Widfeldt, 2004). At this level, I should mention that I will focus more on the latter category, as this will enable me to bridge the gap between these theories and my research question.

Tolerant democratic measures against far-right parties are basically practices typically granting them rights and respect by their representative function in democracies (Bourne, 2022). A good illustration of these, is the forbearance by the other political parties. This strategy can have various depictions. For instance, the form of policy co-optation (Heinze, 2018; Bourne, 2023). Downs (2001) and Bourne (2022) mention that policy co-optation involves parroting or copying at least partially the far-right party’s issue positions. More particularly, the expansion of the mainstream party’s programmatic agenda rightwards to address issues, such as immigration, that triggered support for the far right, will probably motivate some policy-oriented voters to shift their vote back to the mainstream political actor (Heinze, 2018).

“A much more dramatic strategy can be the collaboration with the pariah party (Downs, 2001; Heinze, 2018). Bourne (2022) analyzed four different subtypes of cooperation. First, is electoral cooperation, in which mainstream parties are willing to form electoral alliances with the far-right. Second, governmental cooperation involves the inclusion of populists in governing coalitions. Third, the form of parliamentary cooperation takes the shape of passing legislation and managing parliamentary business. The final form is the one of public cooperation, which involves the inclusion of these parties in activities in the public sphere, as well as in the public political dialogue” (as cited in Filios, 2025). The rationale behind this approach lies not exactly at the normalization of the pariah party in the public opinion, but mainly it aims at mitigating its victimization narrative, and its anti-establishment identity. Thus, one could argue that

voters will evaluate its positions with the same criteria, they evaluate all the established parties.

An additional category of tolerant measures aiming to mitigate the power of illiberal parties is implemented by public authorities. Generally, these actors include the “judicial, legislative, and executive branches of government, the bureaucratic apparatus, state agencies and substate authorities” (Bourne 2022, 2023). These measures are designed to affect all parties, addressing illegal behavior and aiming to affect ideas mainly through education and dialogue. In short, these strategies include measures, related to the institutionalization of a strong checks and balances system, as well as an impartial judicial system (Bourne 2022; Luhrmann et al., 2020). In line with that, Bourne (2022) and Malkopoulou & Moffitt (2025) analyze the strategy of restructuring the electoral rules, to affect the party's vote-to-seat ratios. Similarly, Capoccia (2019) mentioned the idea of “anti-extremist legislation”, which empowers public authorities to deal with an extremist threat, like populist far-right parties in a state of emergency. This encapsulates legislation reforms, or other programmes aiming to address problematic behavior of these parties at the public sphere, such as online hate speech, or propaganda (as cited in Bourne, 2022). “Moreover, another category of tolerant initiatives implemented by public authorities is the persuasion of the public about the adverse implications and extremism for the ecosystem of democracies (Bourne, 2023). The concept of this strategy includes speech and initiatives aiming to persuade citizens about the anti-pluralist illiberal nature of these parties, the existence of which undermines democratic institutions.” (as cited in Filios, 2025).

Tolerant initiatives can also be implemented by civil society actors. This concept refers to “a wide range of non-governmental actors, including lobby, or other social movements, organized by individuals for their own ends” (Bourne, 2023; Luhrmann et al. 2020; Schedler, 2019; Tarrow, 2011). The most common technique used by civil society actors, is the adversarialism against the illiberal ideas (Bourne, 2022). This can take the formulation of information campaigns, boycotts, civil disobedience, demonstrations, strikes, or even the cooperation and the pressure of political parties to use their resources to tackle the extremist ideas (Bourne, 2023; Luhrmann et al. 2020).

On the other hand, intolerant measures subjected to illiberal parties are closely related to the notion of militant democracy. Bourne (2022) highlights that these “harder” measures aim to mitigate the presence of these parties and the impact of their ideas on public policy and political sphere (Luhmann et al. 2020). “Downs (2001) mentions that by the time the established parties collectively recognize far-right parties as a potential threat to democracy, they seek to implement various types of political and legal restrictions” (as cited in Filios, 2025). To begin with, a mainstream party, can decide to ignore the pariah party, as it considers that the salient issue taken by the far-right party not of high importance (Meguid, 2005). Most of the time, it wants to ‘keep clean hands’ (Downs, 2001). Thus, the “mainstream party denies the party’s legitimacy and importance, and hopes that, due to the lack of power and publicity, it will become less attractive to the voters” (Heinze, 2018). However, this strategy is not without risk, as it fails to address the sources of the far-right party’s electoral spike (Downs, 2001).

“More specifically, these “disengage” strategies of isolation can be divided into “legal restrictions” and “blocking coalitions” (Downs, 2001; Van Spanje & Weber, 2019). Some good illustrations of these, are restrictions of certain political rights, such as rights of association and expression, or rights regarding access to public goods, such as state funding (Bourne, 2022)” (as cited in Filios, 2025). There is a variety of parties targeted with these measures, such as the separatist Herri Batasuna in Spain, Golden Dawn in Greece, Vlaams Belang in Belgium, as well the National Democratic Party in Germany (Biard, 2021; European Court of Human Rights, 2009; Ioannidis, 2013; Jores, 2024).

“Bichay (2020) has well analyzed the importance of public financing for the rise of far-right parties, arguing that it provides a large benefit to their campaigning and to their existence, as these parties can hardly retrieve and mobilize monetary support from other private sources. Consequently, limitations on access to state funding by the public authorities present a crucial and challenging problem for their existence” (as cited in Filios, 2025).

Undeniably, there are also other more extreme forms of institutional responses, the most radical of which is the party ban (Bernatskyi, 2024; Lowenstein, 1937; Malkopoulou, 2021). According to Capoccia (2013) and Issacharoff (2007), the imposition of a party ban triggers an inevitable democratic dilemma, that consists of a tension between

militant and tolerant conceptions of democracy. However, Bernatskyi (2024) argues that not all-party bans fall under the notion of militant democracy. His analysis establishes a theoretical basis that distinguishes between three classifications of democratic state orientation towards party dissolution. The liberal model, under which the activities of a party are limited only by the criminal law (e.g. Greece, UK, Iceland, USA, and Australia). The institutional model, which prohibits the functioning of parties that aim to “violate the state independence, the nation sovereignty, or commit acts of political violence that violate human rights” (e.g., Spain, Austria, Belgium, and the Netherlands) (Bernatskyi, 2024, p.760). Last, the militant model, in the heart of which, lies the notion that “the state, and more specifically the legal authorities should prohibit the existence of political parties that promote the abolition of the democratic system as a political goal”. Some good illustrations of this model are Germany, Turkey, and the Czech Republic (Bernatskyi, 2024, p. 760; Bourne & Bertoa, 2017; Müller, 2016;).

“Alternatively, containment of these parties can also be achieved by political ostracism applied by other political parties. Many scholars have highlighted the frequency of political isolation or blocking coalitions as a main response against these actors (Downs, 2012; Turnbull-Dugarte, 2024). According to Downs (2012), this initiative aims to delimit the participation and the impact of populist parties in the public sphere, by refusing to cooperate with them. Consequently, this response signals the denial of access to political power due to their illegitimate and illiberal nature. Despite the above discussion about the term “exceptionality” and the erosion of democratic norms, political ostracism contributes to the goal of limiting the political representation of extremist parties, which lies at the heart of modern democracies” (as cited in Filios, 2025). Refusing any cooperation with these illiberal actors, is often considered undemocratic as it restricts the free and fair political competition for support, which is highly fundamental in democratic regimes (Dahl, 1971). More specifically, current studies identify mainly four subtypes of ostracism. The electoral, the parliamentary, the public, and the governmental (Bourne, 2023; Downs, 2001; Van Spanje & Weber, 2019). Downs (2001) argues that the latter type refers to the term “cordon sanitaire”, which signals the exclusion of parties from governing coalitions. The current literature has identified several populist far-right parties that have been ostracized. Some good illustrations of them are the Center Democrats in the Netherlands in the 1980s and 1990s, and the Flemish Bloc (VB) in Belgium, as five other parties decided

to boycott it in 1989 (Mudde & Van Holsteyn, 2000). As other examples, the National Front (FN) has been ostracized by all other parties in the French national parliament, as well as the National Democratic Party (NPD), which faced a similar restriction in Germany (Van Spanje & Weber, 2019).

Finally, beyond the state’s restrictions against illiberal actors, scholars highlight the role of civil society actors in implementing intolerant strategies to confront the democratic threats. Bourne (2023) and Luhmann et al. (2020) emphasize the strategy of coercive confrontation against the far-right. Tilly (2003) identifies several forms of it, including hunger strikes, shaming ceremonies, scattered attacks, or other clandestine attacks on symbolic objects or throwing vegetables or eggs at politicians. However, Keane (2004) argues that the concept of civil society “has a close affinity with forms of non-coercion” or tolerant ways of expressing disappointment or hostility towards politicians, by eliminating violence from human affairs.

Nevertheless, some of these repressive strategies are often not effective in facing these contemporary challenges of democracy (Müller, 2016). The contribution of Luhmann (2021) sheds light on this issue, implying that those who conceal an anti-pluralist and anti-democratic agenda do not always meet the necessary legal criteria for the implementation of these restrictions due to their moderate populist facade. Thus, many critics of militant democracy argue that governments will use these measures not to defend democracy, but to subvert it (Müller, 2012).

Table 1: Actors and countermeasures toward illiberal parties (Bourne, 2023; Downs, 2001; Heinze, 2018; Luhmann et al., 2020).

Actor	Tolerant–Engage	Intolerant–Disengage
Political parties	• Forbearance • Policy co-optation / cooperation	• Ignore / deny legitimacy • Ostracism / cordon sanitaire
Public authorities	• Checks and balances / independent judiciary • Persuasion / civic education; electoral rule changes	• Rights or access restrictions (incl. funding) • Party ban / dissolution
Civil society	• Information campaigns / advocacy • Peaceful protest, boycotts	• Exclusionary mobilisation • Coercive confrontation

Table 1 summarizes the different actors, as well as the wide range of strategies imposed towards illiberal parties in contemporary European democracies. Drawing on the literature analyzed above, it aims to distinguish the actors in three separate categories, and the strategies into two distinct types of engagement. First, the tolerant approaches, the implementation of which centers on the notion of tolerant democracy. Second, the intolerant-disengagement strategies which focus on delimiting the access and the participation of pariah parties into the public sphere. One significant observation in this level of analysis, is that not all disengagement strategies fall under the notion of militant democracy. Drawing on the above table, there are these intolerant strategies implemented by the public authorities that reflect the idea of militancy per se.

2.3 Electoral implications of democratic self-defense responses

A growing body of literature has made significant strides in explaining the different strategies against the illiberal far right parties. But to my understanding, what is also important to study in parallel is the electoral implications of these responses. Therefore, I consider it worth mentioning for policymakers, as well as for party leaders, to acquire a concise depiction of these effects, due to the unintended consequences that restrictions could have for democratic prevalence. In fact, the comparative literature depicts a large variation in the electoral trajectories of restricted parties (van Spanje & Weber, 2019).

Reflecting on this, existing empirical research on the effectiveness of militant democracy remains mixed (Bourne & Bertoa, 2017; Capoccia, 2005; Van Spanje & De Vreese, 2015). Analysis of militant measures, such as party bans, hate speech prosecution, and political stigmatization on radical parties in Spain, the Netherlands, Belgium, and Turkey demonstrates that militant measures did not create a backlash, or a victimization effect on electoral support for these parties, but can be more successful in containing radical parties, in combination with other more tolerant strategies (Arenas, 2021; Bale, 2007; Downs, 2012; Minkenberg, 2006; Van Spanje and Azrout, 2019). In contrast, Van Heerden & Van der Brug (2017) and Downs et al. (2009) suggest that disengagement strategies have unintended consequences when implemented, once a radical party has already made a successful entry into the party system in the Netherlands. In a later period, no significant effect was found on electoral support.

Similarly, Art (2007) explains that strategies of disengagement might have adverse implications for the political system, once party leaders have become stronger and entrenched in the party system, or when they have a loyal group of supporters and a strong party organization. In the same logic, empirical work of Jacobs and Van Spanje (2020) regarding the effect of legal prosecution of radical party leaders in France, Belgium, the Netherlands, and Germany showed an (in)direct electoral support for them. This in fact highlights that initiating legal prosecution against anti-immigrant far-right parties yields unintended consequences by granting these parties a media platform. In line with this analysis, Van Spanje & De Vreese (2015) suggest that hate speech prosecution against the leader of the Dutch populist PVV might have increased its electoral support, mainly for three reasons. First, drawing on Van Aelst et al. (2008), the media attention gained due to the prosecution will act positively on its electoral performance. Second, the prosecution will strengthen the ideological ties between the targeted party and the issue of immigration, strengthening the “issue ownership”, and thus reinforcing its electoral trajectory (Van der Brug, 2004). Third, as the issue of immigration gains more media attention, it is plausible to believe that it will gain higher importance in the voters’ consciousness, and therefore this can benefit the far-right family electorally, as this permeates ideologically with strict anti-immigrant attitudes (Boomgarden & Vliegenthart, 2007 as cited in Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017).

Another significant contribution on analyzing the electoral effects of ostracism, comes from Van Spanje & Weber (2019). They examine the conditions under which ostracism decreases electoral support for anti-immigration parties, and under which it backfires. Their findings highlighted that while ostracism can prevent a party from gaining access to power in multi-party systems, the effects of this reaction are ambiguous and depend on political context, as well as the power and the size of the party (Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017; Van Spanje & Weber, 2019). In the same vein, Van Spanje & Van der Brug (2009) and Downs et al. (2009), argue that the effect of political ostracism on far-right parties depends on the institutional context, and in particular the threshold for entering parliament, and the influence of opposition parties on policy making. For instance, in two-party majoritarian electoral systems such as that in the United States, or in proportional representation systems with high thresholds for entry into representative assemblies, ostracism may mitigate the spike of extremist parties in the policy-making procedures (Downs, 2012).

On the one hand, Van Spanje & Van der Brug (2009) point out that ostracism has unintended consequences, in favor of the excluded party, in contexts where the influence of opposition parties on policy is strong (e.g., Belgium, Italy). On the other hand, Strøm (1990) argues that in political environments of one-party majority governments, the opposition parties are left without much power unless they are in government, thus it is highly inevitable for their policies to be politically and electorally neglected. However, there are some other determinants that shape voter's behavior towards ostracized parties, such as voter's attitudes towards ostracism, as well as dissatisfaction with the established parties (as cited in Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). More specifically, they observe that in political contexts where opposition influence is low, these considerations may replace the usual policy considerations that lead to decreased electoral support for the ostracized party, strengthening its electoral support.

In support of the above, another aspect that should be considered regarding the effect of restrictions, is the electoral behavior of the targeted party's voters (van Heerden & van der Brug, 2017). They analyze that there are two theories that lead to opposing predictions on the electoral consequences of restrictions. The first theory states that some of the party voters are policy-oriented and behave instrumentally. In other words, one can assume that voters are rational actors who aim to influence the real-life policy outcomes, following the rational choice model (Downs, 1957; Van der Eijk & Franklin, 1996). In this case, these voters support the party when they agree with their program, as well as when they perceive the party as legitimate and effective. However, the implementation of a political or legal restriction automatically delegitimizes the party, mitigating the support of some portion of its electoral body. "Moreover, political ostracism may reduce party support because it decreases the likelihood that these parties will come to power and implement their policies and consequently reduces voters' policy utility of voting for these parties (Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009)" (as cited in Filios, 2025).

In contrast, the second perspective states that a big share of party's supporters is protest voters, whose main aim is to express their discontent towards the establishment (Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). In this case, one can expect that political or legal restrictions against the party will increase support for the party, as restrictions activate

a victimization mechanism against the party. To pose it differently, voters evaluate these measures as unfair, or even that the party is hit below the belt, which makes the party seen as an underdog, that could gain voter's approval (Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017). Han (2020) mentions that party support can be strengthened as these parties are stigmatized, and isolated by the mainstream actors that symbolize the "corrupted" system of liberal democracy, which these parties refute. This aligns with the idea of Downs (2002), who supported that although political exclusion may be a politically "viable" solution on behalf of the establishment, there is a risk of polarizing some protest voters who are already hostile towards the liberal democratic order. Thus, this overeager tendency for political correctness only seems to fuel support for far-right parties (Downs, 2001).

Taken all together, providing evidence regarding the electoral effects of political and legal restrictions remain quite ambivalent. The above analysis illustrated that restrictions activate different mechanisms of voting behavior. To extend my thought, while several studies showed that restrictions mitigate the electoral power of parties, by activating a delegitimization narrative towards them, others suggested that the exclusionary measures provoke a victimization sense, leading to a backlash. In this academic framework, authors shed light on different factors that could explain some of these ambivalent effects, such as the role of the institutional context and the political culture on behalf of the elites, as well as the role of parliamentary opposition parties in policymaking (Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). Thus, while there is an effort to evaluate the effects of restrictions by understanding the contextual factors of each case restrictions are implemented, by treating restrictions in an isolative manner, none has tried to shift the emphasis towards the type and the intensity of restrictions in a comparative way.

To my knowledge it seems that there is no research to date that has pursued to approach this field by analyzing the intensity variation of restrictions. To illustrate, this study adopts an innovative approach by attempting to compare the electoral effects of different types of measures based on their coerciveness, or intensity variation on a targeted party. This will allow one to comprehend how and whether restrictions of different type and intensity activate different mechanisms of voting behavior. More specifically, this thesis will try to answer the following research question "*To what*

extent do the different types of political and legal restrictions on far-right parties affect the electoral support for them? ”, with the use of a survey experiment in Greece.

3. Theoretical Framework and Restrictions’ Typology

3.1 Towards a new analytical approach of restrictions’ variation

There is a large volume of published studies analyzing the various democratic self-defense approaches, as well as the typology of the different restrictions that target illiberal (far-right) parties in contemporary Western democracies. Nowadays, much of the current literature has paid more attention to the electoral footprint of restrictions, analyzing each of them separately, in an individual form. To illustrate this, the existing literature has investigated the effects of party bans, political ostracism, hate speech prosecution, or other types of legal restrictions separately, in single-case analyses. However, little attention has been paid to a comparative and systematic analysis of different types of exclusionary measures within a unified framework. Therefore, this thesis will contribute to the current literature by allowing one to comprehend how the different intensity of political and legal responses targeting parties affect the electoral support for them, in a specific (Greek) political and institutional environment. This system of classification will provide a basis for understanding what kind of voting behavior mechanisms the different types of restrictions activate.

To achieve this, I will place emphasis on three different restrictions. The governmental ostracism, often referred to as *cordon sanitaire*, the cut of state funding, and the possible imposition of a party ban from the elections. My rationale for this choice lies in the fundamental roles that these three restrictions have for a targeted party, in my case, a far-right fictitious party in Greece.

Moving on to the operationalization of the intensity variation, I first need to make clear what exactly this variation represents, and what its theoretical basis is. Generally, the notion of exclusionary measures, against illiberal actors draws on preventing or constraining those aiming at subverting the liberal democratic order (Müller, 2012).

Drawing on that, I conceptualize the “intensity” of these measures as the degree to which they constrain a party’s efficient and functional participation in democratic competition, such as in the representative bodies, or in other aspects of political life.

First, the *cordon sanitaire* signals a restriction not linked to specific legal norms or rules of democratic competition, but it lies at the core of the representational goal in contemporary liberal democracies. Thus, by its implementation, established parties strike a significant blow at the excluded party’s legitimacy (Bourne, 2022; Downs, 2001; Van Spanje & Weber, 2017; Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). The significance of *cordon sanitaire* as a repressive blocking coalition technique has been repeatedly highlighted by scholars. “More specifically, Turnbull-Dugarte (2024) suggests that this political block at the levels of political influence is crucial because it limits access to government portfolios and agenda-shaping power. In line with that, it serves as a signal to citizens that the political system considers the extremist positions of the party as ideas “outside the standards of acceptability” of the system (Akkerman & Rooduijn, 2015)” (as cited in Filios, 2025). For the above reasons, I find it important to include this measure in the variation of restrictions.

The second form of restrictions refers to the cut of state funding for the party. In contrast to the *cordon sanitaire*, which is not linked to any typical rule of democratic politics, restrictive limitations on state funding to parties constitute a legal restriction from the public authorities (Bourne, 2022; Downs, 2002; Luhrmann et al., 2020). Bichay (2020, p.3) has well-analyzed the substantive importance of public funding in increasing the vote share of far-right parties. This arises mainly because of the harder time that these parties have, to remain competitive, raise funds, and attract a coalition of voters (Bichay, 2020; Oklobdzija, 2017). Several scholars have highlighted the low economic power of the far-right voters, and thus their inability to assist the party financially (Ignazi, 2003; Inglehart & Norris, 2016). “Bichay (2020) also argues that public funding serves to disproportionately favor far-right parties, enabling them to mobilize voters and provide them with large benefits for their campaigning. In sum, I do believe that public funding is strongly associated with the organizational existence of these parties, as it serves as a motivational and survival power for them. Consequently, any possible legal restriction to access on public funding to these parties will signal a very adverse trajectory for their political life” (as cited in Filios, 2025).

The third category of institutional responses captures the imposition of a potential party ban from the elections. To illustrate, a party ban constitutes the most repressive instrument of militant democracy, as it prevents a specific party from contesting elections and obtaining any of the benefits that can be retrieved from being in office or holding parliamentary seats (Bernatskyi, 2024; Bourne, 2022; Downs, 2001; Malkopoulou, 2021). This inability to contest elections and hold seats in the representative bodies is clearly associated with a loss of support in two sectors (Arenas, 2021). More specifically, he highlights that the banned party disposes of all the direct material advantages from holding parliamentary representation, as well as faces severe implications in terms of the party's mobilization capacity, and voters' increased information about competing politicians who have been elected in the banned party's place. In other words, "party bans deprive the extremist movement of organizational resources and social visibility" (Arenas, 2021, p.354).

Consequently, from a theoretical perspective a party ban from an election signals the most repressive response (Bernatskyi, 2024; Bourne, 2022; Downs, 2001; Malkopoulou, 2021). Therefore, it should be considered as the most coercive restriction. Then, as a restriction with a lower intensity, I place the legal exclusionary measure on state funding, as it is highly interlinked with the economic sustainability and thus the survival of these parties (Bichay, 2020). Hence, despite the significance of the political exclusionary measure of the cordon sanitaire, I argue that its informal, non-legal- nature classifies it lower in the intensity variation.

3.2 Theoretical expectations

The current section will analyze the underlying theory regarding the expected effects of the exclusionary measures targeting a fictitious far-right party in Greece. First, the dependent variable (DV) is the electoral support, which is proxied by respondents' voting intention in the control and the treatment groups.

Building on the previously analyzed mechanisms of delegitimization, and victimization, I construct the following hypotheses.

The electoral effect of ostracism is quite ambivalent. The mechanism underlying the negative effect of ostracism on a party's electoral support relates to voters' interest in affecting policy outcomes (Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). Consequently, a big share of the party's policy-oriented voters will abstain from voting for it. Moreover, drawing on the analysis of Strøm (1990), ostracism seems to be very effective in constraining the power of the targeted party in contexts where one-party majority governments are flourishing, as well as where the opposition influence can be qualified as low (as cited in Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). All these institutional characteristics hold true in the Greek political context. Therefore, one could argue that a cordon sanitaire would decrease the electoral power of this party, delegitimizing it.

However, Van Spanje & Van der Brug (2009) argue that there are some other determinants shaping voters' behavior towards ostracized parties in these less consensus political environments, such as voters' attitudes towards ostracism, as well as dissatisfaction with established parties. To support this in my case, there is an extensive range of sources highlighting the intense anti-systemic attitudes, "the widespread disenchantment with the political class, the sharp decrease in institutional trust, as well as the rise in political cynicism" of the Greek population towards the political parties and the political establishment (Andronikidou & Korvas, 2012; Kanellopoulos & Kousis, 2018; Kontogiannis-Mandros & Gousis, 2025). Therefore, I expect that the imposition of cordon sanitaire could potentially trigger either the delegitimization or the victimization sense on voter's electoral behavior, and thus its effect can go both ways.

H_{1a}: The imposition of cordon sanitaire on the fictitious party will increase the voting intention for it.

H_{1b}: The imposition of cordon sanitaire on the fictitious party will decrease the voting intention for it.

A growing body of literature has established the fundamental role of public funding on the electoral performance of political parties (Bertoa et al., 2025; Piccio, 2020). Bichay (2020) highlighted the high significance of public funding as a means that

disproportionately aids far-right parties, enabling them to mobilize voters. In contrast with the previous two-directional hypothesis, I argue that this moderate-but legal type of restriction will increase the electoral support for the fictitious far-right party. There are two similar arguments that contribute to this hypothesis. First, although restrictions on state funding will affect negatively the organizational capacity of the party (Bichay, 2020), I argue that this can be seen more like an embattlement mechanism rather than as a restriction to agenda legislation in voters' eyes, as it has been the case in similar legal proceedings against far-right parties in different contexts (Van Spanje & De Vreese, 2015).

The second reason that in a way drives me towards this hypothesis is the following. Previous analysis has highlighted that lack of fundraising makes mobilization and communication with voters extremely hard (Adams et al., 2006). However, I argue that these implications mainly affect the aggregate image and functionality of the party. They are not expected to negatively affect citizens' perceptions about it, as the cut of state funding can be seen as a "legalistic embargo" towards the survival of this party. In combination with the high political and institutional mistrust of the Greek population, my premise is that restrictions on state funding will trigger victimization feelings towards the party, and consequently, I hypothesize that this will increase the voting intention for it.

H₂: The imposition of cuts on the state funding to the fictitious party will increase the voting intention for it.

Several studies have investigated the electoral effects of party bans in pariah parties in various institutional environments, namely in Spain, Belgium, Turkey, Germany and, the Czech Republic, concluding that the implementation of a party ban is not associated with increased popularity of the targeted parties (Arenas, 2021; Bale, 2007; Downs, 2012; Minkenberg, 2006). To my knowledge, there is no previous research suggesting that the imposition of a party ban led to unexpected consequences in a real-world case, such as backlash.

However, party bans are also entrenched with the risk of significant electoral costs (Capoccia, 2005). To illustrate, one should be very careful when examining the possible

implementation of a party ban in the Greek context. First, the Greek institutional framework is unwelcoming of party bans, due to the political atrocities of the authoritarian past, the military junta's dissolution of all political parties in 1967 (Bernatskyi, 2024; Malkopoulou, 2021). However, support for militancy and dissolution of political parties moved from complete rejection to reluctant acceptance (Malkopoulou, 2021). This development can be reflected in two prominent cases. First, the first-ever conviction of a party, the right-extremist Golden Dawn for being an undercover criminal organization, as the constitutional trial ruled that the political and criminal activity of this organization overlapped (Malkopoulou, 2021). Second, the ban of the Golden Dawn's successor party "Ellines" from contesting the national elections in 2023, based on a delayed amendment that blocked the party's leader, and former member of Golden Dawn, Ilias Kasidiaris as he has been sentenced to prison for criminal behavior (Stamatoukou, 2023). However, this latest legislation raised alarming concerns over its constitutionality (Smith, 2023), posing a dangerous precedent and even working in favor of the convicted leader, forcing the extremists to go underground and adopt other possibly more violent, or different political tactics (Capoccia, 2005). In fact, a key illustration of this backlash is reflected in the electoral success of the far-right "Spartiates" party, which won parliamentary representation in 2023, mainly due to the close ties and the endorsement of the convicted leader, Kasidiaris, and other prominent members of Golden Dawn (Smith, 2023).

Considering all this evidence, I hypothesize that the ongoing risk of a ban to the party can go both ways. On the one hand, the literature recommends that it is a very strong signal of delegitimization of the targeted party (Arenas, 2021; Bale, 2007; Downs, 2012; Minkenberg, 2006), while on the other, there are prevalent reasons to assume that in the Greek polarized and low-trust political and institutional environment, it might increase the voting intention for it, as the ban will victimize the party in voters' eyes. This latter argument aligns with Capoccia (2005), as she expected that such restrictive measures will "encounter strong principled opposition in public opinion, as they contradict fundamental democratic principles", leading to an electoral success of the party.

H_{3a}: A possible imposition of a party ban on the fictitious party will increase the voting intention for it, under the condition, it would be eligible to run in the next elections.

H_{3b}: A possible imposition of a party ban on the fictitious party will decrease the voting intention for it, under the condition, it would be eligible to run in the next elections.

3.3 Why Greece?

Although Greece is not a clear illustration of a militant democracy, its latest political, legal and social developments render this country a relevant case for answering my research question, and basically the electoral effects of different types of restrictions on far-right parties. But let me explain the reasons behind this selection.

To begin with, Malkopoulou (2021) provides one with a very clear understanding of why Greece was unwelcoming of party bans up until recently. Her analysis demonstrates two reasons. First, the party ban implemented in the Communist Party after the Civil War in Greece, mainly due to the prevailing anti-communism notion at that era. Second, the dissolution of all political parties during the military junta's regime between 1967-1974. Notably, she mentions that the established Constitutional Court during the authoritarian regime is likened to a puppet, as it was responsible for the continuous supervision of all political actors, and could outlaw them if they were opponents of the regime, even though their actions might be nonviolent and legal. This in fact lowered the legal requirements for prosecution (Malkopoulou, 2021). Therefore, this reluctance towards party bans can be attributed to the normatively tainted practices of the Greek authoritarian past.

However, the electoral spike and the criminal action of the far-right neo-Nazi Golden Dawn triggered a shift from a complete rejection of party bans and other militant measures to a reluctant acceptance of them. Malkopoulou (2021) and Bernatskyi (2024) explain that Greece can be described as a country adopting the liberal/procedural model of democracy towards party bans. In cases like these, the activities of a party, like any other group, are restricted only by the criminal law. Malkopoulou (2021, p.190) highlights that “the criminal indictment for Golden Dawn became possible by arguing

that the criminal and political branch of the party were merged”. Apart from that, a second block of the electoral presence of party, without dismantling it, came in 2023, where the court banned the Golden Dawn’s successor party “Ellines” from contesting national elections, based on a delayed amendment that blocked the party’s leader, as he has been sentenced to prison for crimes against the state (Stamatoukou, 2023). In line with the above, Greece represents a case where all the above political and legal restrictions that I include in my analysis (e.g., political ostracism, restrictions on state funding, and party ban) have been implemented in the case of Golden Dawn (Ministry of Interior, 2013). Consequently, taking also into consideration the intense anti-systemic attitudes, the widespread misalignment with the political class, and the sharp mistrust in institutions and political parties (Exadaktylos & Zahariadis, 2012; Kanellopoulos & Kousis, 2018), I argue that it would be theoretically relevant and highly important to explore the risks that such restrictions entail in terms of public perceptions of democratic legitimacy and voting behavior towards far-right parties in a highly divided political environment (Georgiadou et al., 2025). In support of the above, Levy’s (2008) analysis on different typologies of cases renders Greece as a most likely case analysis to answer my research question. The combination of the above analyzed characteristics such as the previous implementation of restrictions, the low-trust, and the highly disengaged with the political class political environment in Greece provide very plausible and ideal conditions for a realistic experiment. Consequently, Greece can be a very illustrative case, to analyze whether restrictions can have unintended consequences, regarding their intended purpose, leading to a backlash due to the activation of victimization feeling. Thus, this could provide meaningful evidence for politicians, as well as for policymakers.

4. Methodology

4.1 Research Design

The methodological approach I will follow to investigate the electoral effects of different political and legal restrictions on a far-right party in Greece is a survey experiment. Experimental research designs are generally a well-suited strategy to examine causal relationships in political science (Kellstedt & Whitten, 2018). Thus, my experiment is designed as a randomized control trial. This allows me to expose randomly respondents to different restrictions “treatments” and isolate their effect on my key dependent variable (electoral support) from other confounding variables. Although the use of a survey experiment to adequately answer my research question establishes causal effects and high internal validity, concerns arise regarding the strength of the stimuli as well as the degree to which my findings can be generalized across other settings, a concept commonly referred to external validity, as well as the realism in the experimental settings, mainly because my focus is on one single-case analysis. However, this generally raises as a significant concern for survey experiments in total, and not only for my case (Barabas & Jerit, 2010; Devroe & Wauters, 2019). To answer my research question, I use a fictitious far-right party (Party “X”), to avoid projection effects, enhance internal validity, and avoid partisan bias, that is citizens’ attitudes towards real-world parties and their leaders (Kölln, 2024).

The population sample for my survey consists of individuals who are eligible to vote in Greek national elections, in other words, Greek citizens who are at least 17 years old. The survey was administered online, and it was distributed by the QeD social and market research company during the last week of April 2026. The reason behind the allocation of the survey distribution to a research company lies on the need to obtain a representative sample of the Greek population among key demographic dimensions, such as age, sex, income, education, and region. Each respondent was randomly assigned to one of the experimental conditions, with a sample of 250 respondents per group, which leads to a total sample of approximately 1.000 participants. The

participation to the survey was voluntary and the respondents could drop out whenever they wanted to.

With the above three hypotheses in mind, the structure of the survey experiment is the following. After giving their consent and being informed that their answers will remain anonymous, respondents answer background questions on different attitudes and behavior, such as their trust in institutions, electoral behavior, the level of satisfaction with contemporary democracy in Greece, and their sociodemographic situation. These covariates are measured in the pre-test design, as this is the standard approach to avoid post-treatment bias. However, this is not without limitations, as responses might suffer from primacy bias, as they might be disproportionately influenced by the questions placed first, threatening internal validity (Blackwell et al., 2025; Yeark et al., 2022). I select to place the covariates in the pre-test design, as scholars argued that posttreatment measurement of covariates undermines the value of randomization, and cause biases treatment effects, which may lead to misleading research conclusions (Montgomery et al., 2018). Subsequently, each respondent is randomly assigned to one of the four treatment conditions (1 control + 3 treatment groups). All respondents read the following vignette, which describes the political manifesto of a fictitious far-right party, which is set to compete in the national elections. This common vignette ensures that all respondents are provided with information regarding the party's core issue positions and its ideology before being exposed to the treatment manipulation. Thus, in the control group, after reading the vignette, the respondent is asked to declare his/her voting intention in favor of the party on a 7-point scale (low probability corresponds to 1, while 7 corresponds to high probability of voting). To note, that in the control group the party does not face any restriction.

Vignette for Control Group:

“Suppose Party X has presented its political platform. Its agenda focuses on restricting immigration, strengthening public safety, increasing health and education benefits exclusively for Greeks, and protecting the eroded national

identity. It also emphasizes the need to amplify the voice of the people, whose will, is constrained by the elites.”

Treatment groups differ solely in the type of implemented restriction towards the party.

In the first treatment group, respondents read the same vignette, with the addition of the following information.

“The other political parties announced that they would not cooperate with Party X, citing concerns about the stability of the democratic regime.”

In the second treatment group, respondents read the same vignette as in the control group and provided with the following information.

“Party X will participate normally in the elections, but it has been subjected to a significant reduction in the state funding to which it is entitled, following a decision by the Parliament.”

In the third treatment group, respondents read the same vignette, with the addition of the following information.

“A previous Supreme Court ruling banned Party X from participating in the last nation election, as its activities were deemed anti-democratic; however, to date, the decision to lift the ban has not become final.”

After the experimental manipulation, respondents are asked to declare their voting intention towards the party in case it would be eligible to compete in the elections, the level of social acceptance to vote for it, and their sympathy towards it on the same 7-point scale, as secondary outcomes. They are also asked to evaluate whether the restriction imposed on the party constitutes a necessary counterbalance or an abuse of power, as well as whether the restriction changes the level of their sympathy towards it. Although analysis of these secondary outcomes has not been included in this thesis, their analysis is considered a promising path for future research on this topic.

The survey also includes a factual manipulation check. Tye-Williams (2017) mentions that these checks ensure that the independent variable is effectively manipulated or that respondents understood the independent variable in a planned way. In my survey, the manipulation check is placed after the vignette and before the section measuring the dependent variable. It is phrased in the following way: “Based on what you have read, what measure was imposed on Party X?” The respondents can choose between the following answers: (“Political exclusion”, “Cuts to state funding”, “Ban on participating in elections”, “No measure was imposed”). For the control group, the right answer is “No measure was imposed”. For the first treatment group, it is “Political exclusion”, for the second, it is “Cuts to state funding”, and for the last treatment group it is, “Ban on participating in elections”. Respondents who fail to identify the correct answer in each group will not be excluded from the main analysis, as research suggests that their exclusion mixes the effect of preexisting and induced beliefs, increasing the risk of positive findings (Varaine, 2023). In line with this, the limited sample only to attentive subjects, could possibly create a non-randomized selection bias (Aronow et al., 2019). However, a regression analysis with the exclusion of respondents who failed to pass the manipulation check is presented in the main analysis.

4.2 Measures

My main dependent variable is the electoral support for the “Party X”, which is proxied by the intention to vote for it on a 7-point Likert scale (1- “Not at all likely”- 7 “Extremely likely”). I argue that the variable of voting intention is recommended as the most appropriate proxy measure to adequately capture the electoral support towards the party (Mutz, 2011).

The key independent variable lies in the experimental manipulation, notably, the four experimental conditions. The variable is operationalized as categorical with four different distinct categories (1 control + 3 treatment groups). The control group serves as a baseline condition, as the vignette does not mention any imposed restriction on the party, while the other three treatments refer to an implementation of a political or legal restriction. The analysis focus on whether and how the existence and the type of

political and legal restrictions imposed on the fictitious far-right party affect the electoral support for it.

Apart from the key variables, I also include some control variables. Although the randomization was successful across groups (see Chapter 5), I chose to incorporate control variables for reasons of analytical precision, as well as to control for potential confounders. In other words, even if the coefficients are unbiased, due to the successful randomization, inclusion of controls improves precision, reducing standard errors (Gerber & Green, 2012). Some good illustrations are some socio-demographic characteristics, such as age, gender, educational level, ideological self-placement, and institutional trust. The main reason why I control for these factors, is that I want to isolate the effect of the treatment condition, in my case, the imposition of a restriction on the electoral support for a far-right party. First, I control for some sociodemographic attributes, such as age, gender, and education level, as they are deemed to be substantial predictors of voting behavior and other political preferences (Kulachai et al., 2023). These measures are operationalized with relative questions in the pre-treatment section. Subsequently, I account for the ideological self-placement, as studies showed that ideological self-placement on the left-right scale (1-represents left, 2-represents center, 3- represents right) exerts a crucial effect in predicting voting behavior in many contemporary democracies (Caprara et al., 2017). In my case, citizens with more right-wing ideological self-placement would be more likely to vote for the far-right party, regardless of the imposition of restrictions, therefore I should control for it. In line with that, institutional trust is controlled, as citizens' low trust towards political institutions is linked with anti-establishment attitudes, establishing a domain affective dimension that could lead to victimization narratives towards restricted far-right parties, and thus the support for them (Erisen & Vasilopoulou, 2022; Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009). More specifically, respondents were asked to evaluate the degree of trust for the following institutions/political subjects (political parties, government, judiciary), on a 7-point scale (1 corresponds to "Not at all", 7 corresponds to "Absolutely").

Generally, the survey predominantly uses 5-,7-point Likert scales, as they seem to be more reliable and analytically useful than scales with more options (Stantcheva, 2023). Most of the questions and their scales used are standardized and are the most frequently

used in international surveys, such as the European Social Survey and the World Value Survey.

4.3 Data analysis

After the survey fielding was completed, data has been analyzed through Stata statistical software. The choice of the analytical method used was contingent on the data characteristics, which is discussed in the next section of the thesis. The survey was designed in Greek, and translated in English through translation software, DeepL, for reasons of analytical precision.

5. Data

5.1 Sociodemographic composition and balance tables

The survey is based on answers from 1000 Greek citizens over 17 years old. For a more detailed list of the variables used in this study, please refer to Appendix B.

Descriptive statistics are weighted to secure that the sample of the survey is representative of the Greek population, and improve its accuracy (Bethlehem, 2009). To note that survey weights are provided by the QeD company, and are calculated based on gender, age, and geographic region of the Greek population, based on data from the Hellenic Statistical Authority (ΕΛΣΤΑΤ).

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics

Variable	Mean	SD	Min	Max
<i>Continuous variables</i>				
Age (in Years)	48.55	14.474	18	83
Trust political parties	2.21	1.348	1	7
Trust government	2.29	1.619	1	7
Trust justice	2.96	1.675	1	7
Voting intention	3.27	1.986	1	7
<i>Categorical variables (%)</i>				
Gender (Female)	49.3%			
Ideological placement (Left)	33%			
(Centre)	25.4%			
(Right)	41.5%			
Education (Primary/Secondary)	27.4%			
(Tertiary)	55%			
(Post graduate)	17.6%			
N	1,000			

Note: Dependent variable is highlighted. Means are calculated from the weighted sample, while SD from the unweighted.

Table 2 demonstrates the descriptive statistics of the variables used in my model. It includes both numeric and categorical variables for the full sample (N=1000). More precisely, the average age of respondents is 48.5 years old. In terms of gender, female respondents represent 49.3 percent of the population sample. The trust towards the main political actors and institutions remains relatively low, as it fluctuates between 2-3 points on a 7-point scale. Regarding the voting intention towards the far-right party, the table reflects that the score is 3.3 on the same 7-point scale. The table also illustrates the ideological self-placement of respondents. Three out of ten respondents identify themselves as Left, one out of four in the Center of the political spectrum, and four out of ten in the Right. Generally, there were no major numbers of missing values, except for the ideological placement variable, which had 22.3% percent of missing values, and thus this variable was excluded from the main analysis. An analysis including the ideological placement variable, will be added in the Appendix. Regarding education, almost one out of four respondents holds a primary or a secondary degree level, 55% hold a tertiary degree level, and 17.6% are postgraduates.

Table 3 depicts the demographic and behavioral statistics in each of the four treatment groups. To examine whether randomization was successful, I calculated the p-values for the numerical/ continuous variables with F-tests, while chi-square tests were used for the categorical variables (Field, 2024). Table 3 shows that no statistically significant differences were found across the treatment groups ($p > 0.05$). This illustrates that the experimental groups are comparable on key demographic attributes and covariates, inferring that randomization was successful. Generally, the number of respondents in each group is relatively balanced (Control group: 255, Treatment group 1: 258, Treatment group 2: 250, Treatment group 3: 237).

6. Main analysis

6.1 OLS analysis and Results

To analyze my findings and test my hypotheses, I employ Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression analysis. The main analysis includes two models. Model 1 includes only the treatment condition, without controlling for any covariates. Although the randomization was successful across groups, I choose to incorporate control variables for reasons of analytical precision in Model 2, as well to control for potential confounders (Gerber & Green, 2012). Moreover, all models both in the main analysis, as well as in the Appendix include robust standard errors (Kellstedt & Whitten, 2018).

Model 1 and Model 2 are specified as:

Model 1:

$$Y_i = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Pol. Ostracism}_i + \beta_2 \text{Funding Cut}_i + \beta_3 \text{Party Ban}_i + \epsilon_i \quad (1)$$

Model 2:

$$\begin{aligned} Y_i = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Pol. Ostracism}_i + \beta_2 \text{Funding Cut}_i + \beta_3 \text{Party Ban}_i \\ & + \beta_4 \text{Gender}_i + \beta_5 \text{Age}_i + \beta_6 \text{Education}_i \\ & + \beta_7 \text{Trust Parties}_i + \beta_8 \text{Trust Gov.}_i + \beta_9 \text{Trust Justice}_i + \epsilon_i \end{aligned} \quad (2)$$

where:

- Y_i = voting intention for Party X (1–7 scale)
- β_0 = constant, mean voting intention of the control group
- β_1 = effect of political ostracism relative to control group
- β_2 = effect of state funding cut relative to control group
- β_3 = effect of party ban relative to control group
- β_4 = effect of gender
- β_5 = effect of age
- β_6 = effect of educational level
- $\beta_7, \beta_8, \beta_9$ = effects of institutional trust (parties, government, justice)
- ϵ_i = error term

Table 4: OLS Regression Analysis with robust standard errors**Dependent Variable: Voting Intention**

	(1) Model 1	(2) Model 2
Independent Variables		
Control	0.000 (.)	0.000 (.)
Political Ostracism	0.139 (0.18)	0.097 (0.17)
State Funding Cut	0.147 (0.17)	0.105 (0.18)
Party Ban	-0.584** (0.18)	-0.609*** (0.18)
Gender (Male)		-0.365** (0.13)
Age		-0.007 (0.00)
Trust parties		0.011 (0.07)
Trust government		0.132* (0.06)
Trust justice		-0.096 (0.05)
Education		-0.284** (0.09)
Constant	3.373*** (0.12)	4.753*** (0.36)
R ²	0.022	0.052
N	1000	994

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. *** p < 0.001, ** p < 0.01; * p < 0.05

Table 4 illustrates the two main models of the analysis. Model 1 shows the coefficients only for the treatment conditions, while Model 2 includes in the analysis sociodemographic characteristics and covariates. Before moving to the hypothesis testing, I note that R-squared is relatively low in both models, 2.2% and 5.2% respectively. This means that only 2.2% of the variation in the voting intention for the Party X is explained only by the treatment conditions, and only 5.2% by Model 2, included the covariates. However, this seems to be acceptable for the purpose of this research, as the goal is not to explain full variation in the dependent variable of voting intention, but to explore the treatment effect on it.

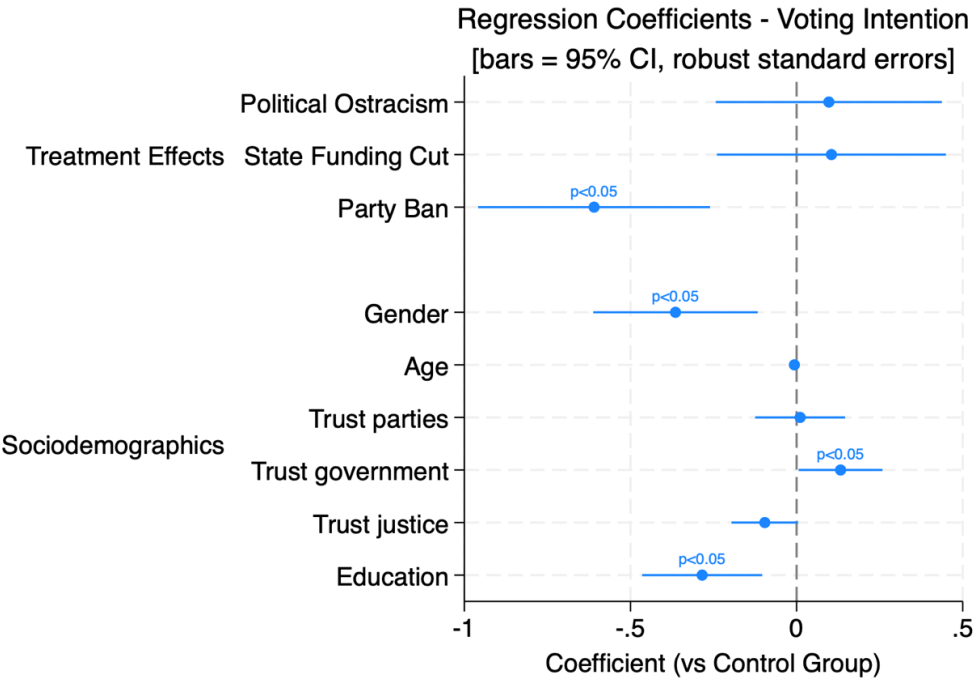


Figure 1: Regression Coefficients from Model 2 with 95% confidence intervals for the DV

In line with Miratrix et al. (2017), the main regression analysis is conducted without survey weights, to avoid the loss of statistical power that accompanies weighting. The authors argue that experiments like these, which have been conducted through online survey companies, secure broadly representative samples and thus they are sufficient without the use of weighting in the main analysis. Following their analysis, Sample

Average Treatment Effects estimates did not seem to differ essentially from the weighted one. Consequently, the following analysis will not be weighted, a weighted one will be presented in the next section.

6.2 Manipulation checks and robustness

The following chapter includes two additional analyses, that serve as robustness checks. First, the one regarding manipulation checks. More specifically, the checks indicate that only 40.8% in the control group, and 37.2% of respondents in the first treatment group successfully identified the correct restrictive measure. In the second treatment group, this number rises at 74.8%, while in the last treatment group, only 55.3% responded correctly to the manipulation check. This raises an important concern as there is a significant portion of respondents in each group who failed to identify the treatment condition, raising issues regarding the attention of the sample. To avoid selection bias and secure randomization (Varaine, 2023), I am adopting the Intention-to-treat-Principle, which centers on the idea that respondents should not be excluded on an experimental setting, even if they have not fully complied to the research conditions (McCoy, 2017). But the relatively small percentages of respondents that successfully passed the manipulation check highlight the limited understanding or attention of some respondents to the treatment stimuli. This could possibly lead to an attenuation of the expected treatment effects. Therefore, a per-protocol analysis, which includes only the respondents who passed the manipulation check, is shown in Table 5 below, serving as a robustness check (Molero-Calafell et al., 2024).

Table 5: Regression Analysis-Failed manipulation checks excluded**DV: Voting intention**

	(3) Model 3	(4) Model 4
Independent variables		
Control	0.000 (.)	0.000 (.)
Political Ostracism	0.123 (0.27)	0.076 (0.27)
State Funding Cut	0.407 (0.23)	0.363 (0.24)
Party Ban	-0.485 (0.25)	-0.453 (0.26)
Gender (Male)		-0.313 (0.17)
Age		-0.005 (0.01)
Trust parties		0.036 (0.09)
Trust government		0.087 (0.08)
Trust justice		-0.141* (0.07)
Education		-0.295* (0.13)
Constant	3.096*** (0.19)	4.529*** (0.53)
R ²	0.032	0.060
N	518	518

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. *** p < 0.001, ** p < 0.01; * p < 0.05

Table 5 (N=518) illustrates the regression analysis, that excludes the failed respondents of the manipulation checks. It shows that the results remain consistent with the main

findings, however the effect of the third treatment group (party ban) falls from 99.9% to 90% statistical significance level ($b=-0.45$, $p=0.078$), suggesting sensitivity in this result.

Table 6: Weighted Regression analysis

DV: Voting Intention

	(6)	(7)
	Model 6	Model 7
Independent Variables		
Control	0.000 (.)	0.000 (.)
Political Ostracism	0.296 (0.21)	0.241 (0.20)
State Funding Cut	0.197 (0.21)	0.151 (0.21)
Party Ban	-0.391 (0.22)	-0.405 (0.21)
Gender (Male)		-0.287 (0.15)
Age		-0.009 (0.00)
Trust parties		-0.058 (0.08)
Trust government		0.161* (0.07)
Trust justice		-0.109 (0.06)
Education		-0.387*** (0.11)
Constant	3.243*** (0.15)	4.941*** (0.40)
R ²	0.017	0.050
N	1000	994

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$

Moreover, to assess the robustness of my findings, I employ an additional analysis, a weighted regression analysis, which applies survey weights is conducted. Table 6 shows that the findings remain robust, the effect of party ban falls marginally from statistical significance at 95% level, ($b=-0.40$, $p=0.055$), reflecting the loss of statistical power that accompanies weighting (Miratrix et al., 2017). In total, robustness checks support the credibility of my findings, verifying the yielded negative effect of party ban on voting intention for the far-right party.

Finally, another model including the ideological placement variable has been employed ($N=776$). Results remain robust as the negative effect of party ban ($b=-0.47$, $p=0.015$) remains statistically significant at 95% level. Ideological placement arises as a strong and statistically significant predictor of voting behavior ($b=0.82$, $p=0.00$) at 99.9% level (presented in Appendix).

6.3 Hypothesis testing

Hypothesis 1a, 1b compares the voting intention between the first treatment group of political ostracism, and the control group. The coefficient is positive in both Models, 0.139 in Model 1, and 0.097 in Model 2. This provides us with knowledge that H_{1a} could be confirmed however, none of the coefficients is statistically significant at 95% level. Consequently, both H_{1a} , and H_{1b} are not supported, meaning that the imposition of a cordon sanitaire does not hold any significant effect on voting intention for the fictitious far-right party.

Hypothesis 2 compares the voting intention between the second treatment of the imposition of restrictions on state funding, and the control group. The coefficient is 0.147 in Model 1, and 0.105 in Model 2. However, like the previous hypothesis, the coefficient is not statistically significant at 95% level. Therefore, H_2 is rejected, suggesting that restrictions on state funding for the fictitious far-right party do not increase voting intention for it.

Hypothesis 3a, 3b focus on the difference in voting intention between the third treatment group of the imposition of a potential party ban, and the control group. The coefficient is -0.584 in Model 1, and -0.609 in Model 2. In contrast with the previous

two hypotheses, both coefficients are statistically significant at 99% and at 99.9% level, respectively. This supports H_{3b} , suggesting that the imposition of a potential party ban will decrease the voting intention for the fictitious far right party ($p=0.001$). More specifically, the coefficient suggests that the potential party ban will decrease the voting intention by 0.6 points in the 7-point scale, controlling for other potential explanations. **The confirmation of H_{3b} reflects the activation of the delegitimization mechanism** towards the far-right party, rather than the victimization one, as party ban decreases voting intention.

6.4 Covariates and sociodemographic attributes

In terms of the control variables included in Model 2, Table 4 indicates that gender's coefficient (-0.365) is statistically significant at 99% level, controlling for other factors. Thus, this means that gender is a significant predictor of voting intention towards the far-right party. More specifically, female respondents score 0.36 points lower in the voting intention 7-point scale for the Party X, compared to male respondents. Surprisingly, trust in government also holds a significant effect on voting, as the coefficient 0.132 is statistically significant at 95% level, when controlling for other potential confounders. This could possibly be explained by the center-right ideological makeup of the government and the close affinity that some of the government's voters could have with the far-right spectrum in Greek politics. One point increase in trust in government variable on the 7-point scale reflects 0.13 points increase in the voting intention for Party X. Finally, the coefficient for education (-0.284, $p=0.002$) is statistically significant at 99% level. So, each one unit increase in the educational level is associated with -0.28 points decrease in voting intention, controlling for other factors. This means that higher education is negatively associated with voting for the far-right, aligning with the existing literature (Schäfer & Steiner, 2025). Although age is a genuine predictor of voting behavior for the far-right (Van der Brug et al., 2026), my evidence reveals that it does not hold any statistically significant effect ($b=-0.007$, $p=0.159$).

7. Discussion

7.1 Experimental findings and policy implications

The current thesis pursued to shed light on the electoral consequences of “self-defense” democratic restrictions with the use of a randomized survey experiment on a fictitious far-right party in Greece. By introducing an intensity variation framework of restrictions, my thesis tried to examine how different types of restriction to a far-right party affect the voting intention for it. The core tension lies on whether the restriction delegitimizes the party in voter’s eyes (Arenas, 2021; Bale, 2007; Van Spanje & Van der Brug, 2009), or it equates it to a recipient of unfair measures, victimizing it (Jacobs & Van Spanje, 2020; Van Heerden & Van der Brug, 2017).

More generally, it is worth mentioning that in terms of the expectations, two out of three hypotheses were formulated as bidirectional, meaning that there were reasonable reasons to expect that the effect of restrictions could go both ways. However, it was only the H_{3b} that could be confirmed.

To illustrate, one important finding is the null effect of restrictions with lower and moderate intensity, political ostracism, and cuts on state funding, respectively. In essence, it reflects that measures, that are theoretically less coercive do not affect citizens’ voting behavior in the Greek context. This aligns with the idea that they mainly have an impact only on the aggregate image of the party, the organizational capacity, and its functionality (Bichay, 2020), at least in the Greek political context.

One careful theoretical consideration, which remains untestable, is the following. If one considers the low-trust levels towards the Greek political parties, they could argue that milder restrictions are visualized as actions of political maneuvering, or as strategies aiming to serve political benefits, for instance winning back voters that previously voted for them, and chose to change their electoral preference in favor of the targeted party. For instance, political ostracism on the far-right party might lower its access on legislative agenda, leading some policy-oriented party’s voters on other mainstream parties with similar but moderate ideological characteristics inside the limits of

democratic acceptability. Consequently, these are seen more like weak measures serving established parties' motivations, rather than as measures taken to "protect" liberal democracy and therefore could not affect public's opinion voting intention, canceling out the activation of each mechanism.

Another finding that stands out is the negative and statistically significant effect of the party ban. The implementation of a potential party ban towards the party decreased by 0.6 points of the 7-point scale the voting intention towards the fictitious party, compared to the control group, when controlling for other factors. In other words, the party ban signals that the party's existence is outside the standards of democratic acceptability for the Greek population. This finding is also consistent with evidence from Arenas (2021), and Bale (2007), confirming the delegitimization character that a party ban exerts in public opinion.

This suggests that in an idiosyncratic low institutional trust political environment, only the most coercive and most typical measure of militant democracy exerts an effect on voting behavior. Despite the intense anti-systemic attitudes towards the political establishment, that could favor the activation of the victimization narrative, evidence shows that Greek citizens are more prone to accept the legitimacy of a party ban, considering the targeted actor as a pariah, rather than disputing the judicial decisions.

However, judicial authorities should be careful, when implementing this restriction, as despite its effectiveness, it raises as the most restrictive and controversial instrument implemented to curb an illiberal party. Only if, judicial authorities act independently, without seeking to benefit political interests of established parties, will democracy's interest be served appropriately.

Taken all together, the evidence highlighted that there is a threshold dynamic of restrictions' intensity needed, to activate the delegitimization mechanism towards the fictitious party. More precisely, the findings did not point out to any linear relationship between the intensity of restrictions and voting intention. This dynamic carries substantial policy implications that could foster the strategy of policymakers, parties, and public authorities, in facing contemporary eroders of democracy in Greece, and more generally into other similar contexts.

Future research could possibly expand the scope of research more broadly, including the analysis of cross-country comparisons with the use of similar experimental methods. For instance, inclusion of countries with different institutional characteristics, or with different experiences with militant democracy and restrictions, could be insightful, especially for policymakers and democratic actors, as to assess whether restrictions with different intensity produce different analytical results.

7.2 Limitations

My analysis does not come without limitations. More specifically, my endeavor is plagued by limited external validity. This raises concerns regarding the degree to which my findings can be generalized across other settings. However, this is a common weakness of the survey experiments (Barabas & Jerit, 2010; Devroe & Wauters, 2019). In line with that, the use of a fictitious party in a single case-country analysis also poses a significant threat for external validity and generalizability of the findings (Walker & Carr, 2021). Moreover, one could argue that the use of voting intention support is not the best proxy to capture electoral support in experimental settings, as it is subjected to social desirability bias, as voting for far-right parties is often rendered to be a stigmatized action. This creates underreported support for these parties, because voters are trying to avoid the adverse effect of social norms of this political preference (Matsunaga & Van Spanje, 2026; Valentim, 2024). However, Mutz (2011) argues that the metric of voting intention corresponds adequately to the measurement of electoral support, as it is rendered to be the standard proxy in public opinion surveys. Similarly, Stantcheva (2023) mentions that online surveys relieve the pressure raised from the social stigma regarding voting choices, as respondents answer the survey with complete privacy and anonymity. Another issue might arise from the inclusion of the respondents who fail to pass the manipulation check, however results remain similar, even if with lower statistical significance. The issue that appears is that the survey is not restricted only to a sample that truly understands the experimental condition, and this could possibly lower the quality of data (Aronow et al., 2019).

Conclusions

The purpose of this master's thesis was to examine whether different types of political and legal restrictions, close to the idea of militant democracy, implemented on a far-right party could affect the voting intention for it. This thesis provides new insights into electoral effects of democratic restrictions, contributing to the existing literature in two ways. First, it offers a comparative evaluation of the electoral effects of different measures rather than focusing on the effect of one. Second, it creates a framework for analyzing whether and how different restrictions based on their intensity affect voting intention, using an experimental design in Greece. To my knowledge, there is no existing comparative study analyzing how the different variation in the intensity of restrictive measures towards parties affect the voting support for them.

Null effects of political ostracism and cuts on state funding on voting intention carry important policy implications. This shows that in the widely misaligned with the political parties and political elites Greek party system, the imposition of informal, in the case of political ostracism, as well as more moderate, and legally binding restrictions towards the far-right, will not make any substantial differences in parties' electoral fortunes, as these restrictions do not shape voting behavior. Thus, policymakers or parties that adopt these measures should think carefully about their implementation, as they seem to be ineffective towards their intentional goal.

My findings suggest that it is only the most coercive instrument of militant democracy that affects voting behavior towards an illiberal far-right party in Greece. This raises as a remarkable conclusion as the country is not a clear illustration of militant democracy. From citizens' perspective, the ban is illustrated as a socially acceptable measure that protects Greece's democratic stability from illiberal eroders that seek to subvert it (Arenas, 2021). This signals that citizens' democratic attachment overrides the widely misalignment with the judicial and political system. In other words, in the name of protecting democracy, citizens' dissatisfaction with the establishment is overlooked.

In conclusion, my thesis highlights that restrictions of different intensities do not have identical electoral implications. Rather than suggesting a linear relationship between

restrictions' intensity, and voting intention towards the targeted party, this study highlighted the threshold dynamic that appears to matter, so that a mechanism, in this case the delegitimization one, could be activated. However, the question of whether the interests of democracy are best served by the surpassing of this threshold, the implementation of a potential party ban in the Greek case, is still an unanswered question.

Appendix A: Survey

Survey in English

Experimental Treatment-Vignettes analysis

Group 1: Control Group (Baseline condition-No restrictions)

Suppose Party X has presented its political platform.

Its agenda focuses on restricting immigration, strengthening public safety, increasing health and education benefits only for Greeks, and the protection of the eroded national identity. It also emphasizes the need to amplify the voice of the people, whose will is constrained by the political elite.

Group 2: Treatment Group 1 (Political Ostracism)

Suppose Party X has presented its political platform.

Its agenda focuses on restricting immigration, strengthening public safety, increasing health and education benefits exclusively for Greeks, and protecting the eroded national identity. It also emphasizes the need to amplify the voice of the people, whose will, is constrained by the elites.

The other political parties announced that they would not cooperate with him, citing concerns about the stability of the democratic system.

Group 3: Treatment Group 2 (Restrictions on state funding)

Suppose Party X has presented its political platform.

Its agenda focuses on curbing immigration, strengthening public safety, increasing health and education benefits exclusively for Greeks, and protecting the eroded national identity. He also emphasizes the need to amplify the voice of the people, whose will

is constrained by the elites.

The party will participate normally in the elections but has been subjected to a significant reduction in the state funding it is entitled to, following a decision by the Parliament.

Group 4: Treatment Group 3 (Party ban)

Suppose Party X has presented its political platform.

Its agenda focuses on restricting immigration, strengthening public safety, increasing health and education benefits only for Greeks, and the protection of the eroded national identity. It also emphasizes the need to amplify the voice of the people, whose will is restricted by the elites.

Following a previous Supreme Court ruling, Party X was barred from participating in the last national election, as its activities were deemed anti-democratic; however, to date, the decision to lift the ban has not become final.

Manipulation check (Control Group)

According to what you have read, which measure was imposed on Party X?

Answer options: Political ostracism, Restrictions on state funding, Party ban, **None of the above (correct answer)**

Manipulation check (Treatment Group 1)

According to what you have read, which measure was imposed on Party X?

Answer options: **Political ostracism (correct answer)**, Restrictions on state funding, Party ban, None of the above

Manipulation check (Treatment Group 2)

According to what you have read, which measure was imposed on Party X?

Answer options: Political ostracism, **Restrictions on state funding (correct answer)**, Party ban, None of the above

Manipulation check (Treatment Group 3)

According to what you have read, which measure was imposed on Party X?

Answer options: Political ostracism, Restrictions on state funding, **Party ban (correct answer)**, None of the above

Dependent Variables:

Below are some questions regarding your stance and position on Party X.

Key Dependent Variable: Voting intention

Question: How likely are you to vote for Party X in the next national election? (1 = Not at all likely, 7 = Very likely)

Secondary Dependent Variable: Sympathy for the party (measured but not used)

Please indicate how much you agree with the following statement.

Question: I feel sympathy for Party X. (1 = Not at all, 7 = Completely)

Secondary Dependent Variable: Level of social acceptance to vote for the party (measured but not used)

Question: In general, do you think it is socially acceptable in this country to vote for Party X? (1 = Not at all, 7 = Very much)

Covariates & Sociodemographic Characteristics

Gender: Please indicate your gender: 1=Male, 2= Female

Education: Please indicate your level of education: 1=None, 2= Elementary school graduate / up to 6 years of education, 3= Middle school graduate / up to 9 years of education, 4= High school graduate / up to 12 years of education, 5= Graduate of a Higher School College, Technical Educational Institute (TEI), Post-secondary Vocational Training Institute (IEK), 6=Graduate of a University/ 16+ years of education, 7= Holder of a master's degree in studies, 99= I do not wish to answer this question (**recoded as 1-4: Primary, 5-6: Tertiary, 7: Post-graduate, 99=None of the above**)

Institutional Trust: In general, how much would you say you trust the following: (1 = Not at all, 7 = Completely). (Political parties, The government, The justice system)

Age: Please indicate your age

Ideological self-placement: Please indicate your ideological self-placement: (1=Left, 2=Center, 3=Right, 9=None of the above)

Survey in Greek

Experimental Treatment-Vignettes analysis

Group 1: Control Group (Baseline condition-No restrictions)

LOGIC Show/hide trigger exists.

4330

53. Έστω ότι το Κόμμα Χ παρουσίασε το πολιτικό του πρόγραμμα.

Η απξέντα του επικεντρώνεται στον περιορισμό της μετανάστευσης, την ενδυνάμωση της δημόσιας ασφάλειας, την αύξηση των παροχών για την υγεία και την εκπαίδευση μόνο για τους Έλληνες, και την προστασία της διαβρωμένης εθνικής ταυτότητας. Υπογραμμίζει επίσης, την ανάγκη ενίσχυσης της φωνής του λαού, η βούληση του οποίου περιορίζεται από τις πολιτικές ελίτ.

Group 2: Treatment Group 1 (Political Ostracism)

LOGIC Show/hide trigger exists.

4336

57. Έστω ότι το Κόμμα Χ παρουσίασε το πολιτικό του πρόγραμμα.

Η απξέντα του επικεντρώνεται στον περιορισμό της μετανάστευσης, την ενδυνάμωση της δημόσιας ασφάλειας, την αύξηση των παροχών για την υγεία και την εκπαίδευση μόνο για τους Έλληνες, και την προστασία της διαβρωμένης εθνικής ταυτότητας. Υπογραμμίζει επίσης, την ανάγκη ενίσχυσης της φωνής του λαού, η βούληση του οποίου περιορίζεται από τις ελίτ.

Τα υπόλοιπα πολιτικά κόμματα ανακοίνωσαν ότι δεν θα συνεργαστούν μαζί του, επικαλούμενα ανησυχίες για την σταθερότητα του δημοκρατικού πολιτεύματος.

Group 3: Treatment Group 2 (Restrictions on state funding)

Logic Show/hide trigger exists.

4343

62. Έστω ότι το Κόμμα Χ παρουσίασε το πολιτικό του πρόγραμμα.

Η απτζέντα του επικεντρώνεται στον περιορισμό της μετανάστευσης, την ενδυνάμωση της δημόσιας ασφάλειας, την αύξηση των παροχών για την υγεία και την εκπαίδευση μόνο για τους Έλληνες, και την προστασία της διαβρωμένης εθνικής ταυτότητας. Υπογραμμίζει επίσης, την ανάγκη ενίσχυσης της φωνής του λαού, η βούληση του οποίου περιορίζεται από τις ελίτ.

Το κόμμα θα συμμετέχει κανονικά στις εκλογές, αλλά του έχει επιβληθεί σημαντική μείωση των πόρων της κρατικής χρηματοδότησης που δικαιούται, μετά από απόφαση της Βουλής.

Group 4: Treatment Group 3 (Party ban)

Logic Show/hide trigger exists.

4349

67. Έστω ότι το Κόμμα Χ παρουσίασε το πολιτικό του πρόγραμμα.

Η απτζέντα του επικεντρώνεται στον περιορισμό της μετανάστευσης, την ενδυνάμωση της δημόσιας ασφάλειας, την αύξηση των παροχών για την υγεία και την εκπαίδευση μόνο για τους Έλληνες, και την προστασία της διαβρωμένης εθνικής ταυτότητας. Υπογραμμίζει επίσης, την ανάγκη ενίσχυσης της φωνής του λαού, η βούληση του οποίου περιορίζεται από τις ελίτ.

Με προηγούμενη δικαστική απόφαση του Αρείου Πάγου, απαγορεύτηκε στο Κόμμα Χ να λάβει μέρος στην τελευταία αναμέτρηση εθνικών εκλογών, καθώς κρίθηκε ότι η δράση του κρίθηκε αντιδημοκρατική, όμως μέχρι σήμερα η απόφαση για άρση της απαγόρευσης δεν έχει τελεσιδικήσει.

Manipulation check

The manipulation check is placed in the post-treatment section, just after the vignette, and before the measurement of the DV, in each group.

Σύμφωνα με τα όσα διάβασες, ποιο μέτρο επιβλήθηκε στο Κόμμα Χ; *

- ☐ Πολιτικός αποκλεισμός
- ☐ Περικοπή στην κρατική χρηματοδότηση
- ☐ Απαγόρευση συμμετοχής στις εκλογές
- ☐ Δεν επιβλήθηκε κανένα μέτρο

Dependent Variables:

Παρακάτω δίνονται ορισμένες ερωτήσεις σχετικά τη στάση και τη θέση σας έναντι του Κόμματος Χ.

Key Dependent Variable: Voting intention

Πόσο πιθανό είναι να ψηφίσετε το Κόμμα Χ στις επόμενες εθνικές εκλογές; (1=Καθόλου Πιθανό, 7= Απολύτως Πιθανό)

Secondary Dependent Variable: Sympathy for the party (measured but not used)

Δηλώστε μας πόσο συμφωνείτε με την παρακάτω θέση.

Νιώθω συμπάθεια για το Κόμμα Χ. (1= Καθόλου, 7=Απόλυτα)

Secondary Dependent Variable: Level of social acceptance to vote for the party (measured but not used)

Γενικά, πιστεύετε ότι είναι κοινωνικά αποδεκτό στη χώρα να ψηφίζει κάποιος το Κόμμα Χ? (1= Καθόλου, 7=Πάρα πολύ)

Covariates & Sociodemographic Characteristics

Φύλο: Παρακαλώ υποδείξτε το φύλο σας: 1=Άνδρας, 2=Γυναίκα

Εκπαίδευση: Παρακαλώ υποδείξτε το επίπεδο εκπαίδευσής σας: 1=Καμία, 2= Απόφοιτος δημοτικού σχολείου / έως 6 έτη εκπαίδευσης, 3= Απόφοιτος γυμνασίου / έως 9 έτη εκπαίδευσης, 4= Απόφοιτος λυκείου / έως 12 έτη εκπαίδευσης, 5= Απόφοιτος Ανώτατης Εκπαίδευσης, Τεχνικού Εκπαιδευτικού Ιδρύματος (ΤΕΙ), Ινστιτούτου Επαγγελματικής Εκπαίδευσης (ΙΕΚ), 6=Απόφοιτος πανεπιστημίου / 16+ έτη εκπαίδευσης, 7= Κάτοχος μεταπτυχιακού τίτλου σπουδών, 99= Δεν επιθυμώ να απαντήσω σε αυτή την ερώτηση

Εμπιστοσύνη σε θεσμούς: Γενικά, πόσο θα λέγατε ότι εμπιστεύεστε τα ακόλουθα: (1 = Καθόλου, 7 = Πλήρως). (Πολιτικά κόμματα, Η κυβέρνηση, Το δικαστικό σύστημα)

Ηλικία: Παρακαλώ δηλώστε την ηλικία σας: 2= 17-24 ετών, 3= 25-34 ετών, 4= 35-44 ετών, 5= 45-54 ετών, 6= 55-64 ετών, 7= 65-74 ετών, 8= 75+ ετών

Ιδεολογική αυτοτοποθέτηση: Παρακαλώ υποδείξτε την ιδεολογική σας αυτοτοποθέτηση: (1=Αριστερά, 2=Κέντρο, 3=Δεξιά, 9=Κανένα από τα παραπάνω)

Appendix B: Operationalization of variables

group_n: 1=Control, 2=Political Ostracism, 3=State Funding Cut, 4=Party Ban

gender: Please indicate your gender: 1=Male, 2= Female

education : Please indicate your level of education: 1=None, 2= Elementary school graduate / up to 6 years of education, 3= Middle school graduate / up to 9 years of education, 4= High school graduate / up to 12 years of education, 5= Graduate of a Higher School College, Technical Educational Institute (ΤΕΙ), Post-secondary Vocational Training Institute (ΙΕΚ), 6=Graduate of a University/ 16+ years of education, 7= Holder of a master's degree in studies, 99= I do not wish to answer this question, (recoded as 1-4: Primary, 5-6: Tertiary, 7: Post-graduate, 99=None of the above)

Institutional Trust (trust_parties, trust_government, trust_justice): In general, how much would you say you trust the following: (1 = Not at all, 7 = Completely). (Political parties, The government, The justice system)

Age (years): Please indicate your age.

ideological_placement: Please indicate your ideological self-placement: (1=Left, 2=Center, 3=Right, 9=None of the above)

Region: Please indicate your region of staying: (1=Athens, 2=Attica (outside of Athens), 3= Epirus=Western Macedonia, 4=Thessaloniki, 5=Macedonia-Thrace, 6=Thessaly-Western Greece, 7= Peloponnesus-Western Grece and Ionian Islands, 8=Agaio, 9=Crete)

Q: Do you generally believe that most people can be trusted, or that one should be cautious and suspicious of people? (1=We should be cautious, 5= Most people can be trusted)

Political Interest: (1=Very Low, 4=Very high)

Q: Regardless of how much trust you place in the institutions mentioned above, do you believe that modern democracy is the best form of government we can have? (1=YES, 2=NO)

Q: Many argue that the problems of modern democracy could be solved if power were assumed by a strong leader who would not be constrained by Parliament or the judiciary, and who could bypass the rules to be effective. Do you agree or disagree with this view? (1=Completely disagree, 3= Neither agree nor disagree, 5=Completely agree)

Professional background: 1= Student, 2= Full time employee, 3=Part-time employee, 4=Self-employed, 5=Military service, 6= Maternity/paternity leave, 7= Retired, 8=Unemployed, 9=Homemaker. 10=Unpaid leave, 11= Unable to work, 12=Hourly wage, 99= I prefer to answer

weight: Provided by the QeD research company, as to acquire a representative sample. Used in the descriptive statistics, and in regression models as robustness checks

manipulation_check1: 0= Political Ostracism, 2=Cuts on state funding, 3=Party ban, 4=No measure was imposed

manipulation_check2: 0= Political Ostracism, 2=Cuts on state funding, 3=Party ban, 4=No measure was imposed

manipulation_check3: = Political Ostracism, 2=Cuts on state funding, 3=Party ban, 4=No measure was imposed

manipulation_check4: = Political Ostracism, 2=Cuts on state funding, 3=Party ban, 4=No measure was imposed

Q: What did you vote for in the previous elections?

vote_1: previous vote for ND (New Democracy)

vote_2: previous vote for SYRIZA

vote_3: previous vote for PASOK

vote_4: previous vote for KKE (Communist Party)

vote_5: previous vote for other far-right party

vote_6: previous vote for other left party

(1=vote for this party, “.”=missing values, do not vote for this party)

Note: Some of the variables operationalized in the Appendix were measured in the survey but were not used for the purposes of this thesis. Future research would include all the variables.

Appendix C: Robustness checks

Table 7: Regression analysis (including Ideological Placement)

DV: Voting Intention

Independent Variables	(5)
	Model 5
Control	0.000 (.)
Political Ostracism	0.052 (0.19)
State Funding Cut	0.181 (0.19)
Party Ban	-0.471* (0.19)
Gender (Male)	-0.227 (0.13)
Age	-0.013** (0.00)
Trust parties	0.036 (0.07)
Trust government	0.013 (0.07)
Trust justice	-0.094 (0.05)
Education	-0.306** (0.10)
Ideological Placement	0.828*** (0.09)
Constant	3.263*** (0.42)
R ²	0.176
N	776

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. *** p < 0.001, ** p < 0.01; * p < 0.05

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